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Hong Kong

Hong Kong (香港 *Hēunggóng* in [Cantonese](#)) is a city with multiple personalities. The population is mainly Chinese, but British influence is still quite visible. It has absorbed people and cultural influences from places as diverse as [Vietnam](#) and [Vancouver](#) and proudly proclaims itself to be *Asia's World City*.

Hong Kong is a global financial hub, and has been a major destination for tourists and business people from around the world for at least a century. Today it is also a major tourism destination for mainland China's increasingly affluent population.

Hong Kong is much more than a harbour city with crowded streets: this territory with its cloudy mountains and rocky islands also offers rural landscapes with breathtaking views. Much of the countryside is classified as Country Park and, although 7.4 million people (2021) are never far away, it is possible to find pockets of wilderness that will reward the more intrepid traveller.

Hong Kong has a subtropical climate with at least one season to match your comfort zone. Boasting one of the world's best airports, it is the ideal first stop for those on their way deeper into [China](#) and further Asia.

Districts

Hong Kong Island (香港島) ([Central](#), [East Coast](#), [South Coast](#))

The site of the original British settlement, the main centre of finance and government, and the main focus of most tourists. Here you will find Hong Kong's tallest skyscrapers, as well as its most historically significant colonial buildings. **The Peak** is the tallest point on the island, with the best views.

Kowloon (九龍)

The peninsula to the north of Hong Kong Island, with great views of the island. It offers a chaotic mix of malls, street markets, and residential tenements. Kowloon is one of the most densely populated places in the world. Kowloon includes **Tsim Sha Tsui** (尖沙咀) and its many budget hotels and upscale stores, and **Mong Kok** (旺角), a shopping district.

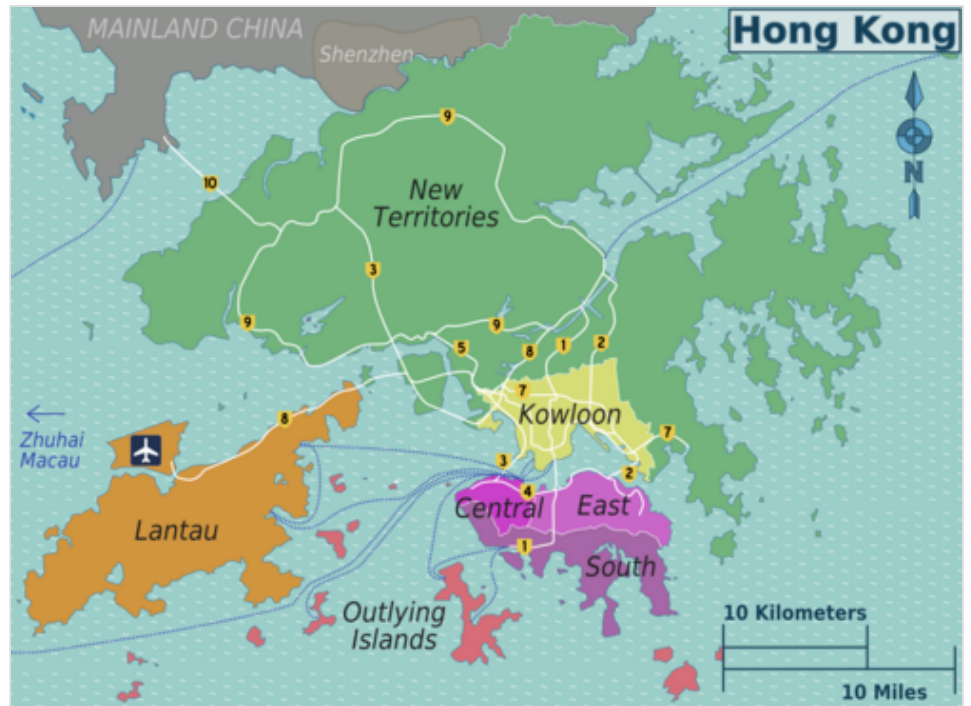
New Territories (新界)

The New Territories contain a curious mix of small farms, villages, industrial installations, mountainous country parks and towns.

Lantau Island

(大嶼山)

A large island west of Hong Kong Island. You will not find many idyllic villages, but once you get over the ramshackle buildings you will find beautiful mountains and beaches. The airport, Hong Kong Disneyland, and the Ngong Ping cable car are found here.



Map of Hong Kong

Outlying

Islands (離島)

These islands surrounding Hong Kong Island are well-known weekend destinations for Hongkongers. Highlights include Lamma (南丫島), known for its seafood and Cheung Chau (長洲), a small island that attracts seafood aficionados, windsurfers and sunbathing day trippers.

Understand

"Hong Kong" means "fragrant harbour" in Cantonese.

Although part of China, Hong Kong operates as a Special Administrative Region under the slogan "One Country, Two Systems" with a high degree of autonomy, retaining most laws and government structures from colonial times. Visa requirements, laws, currency, culture and language have a

	
Currency	Hong Kong dollar (HKD)
Population	7.4 million (2021)

heritage from the time of British rule, so for most tourists Hong Kong feels like a different country. Hong Kong enjoyed many Western-style freedoms and many locals were proud of it. The ideals of a free and open society were firmly rooted here, but a significant degree of freedom was curtailed when the National Security Law was imposed in 2020 and Article 23 was implemented locally in 2024.

Electricity	220 volt / 50 hertz (BS 1363)
Country code	+852
Time zone	UTC+08:00
Emergencies	999
Driving side	left
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History

“大英帝國從海上來，又從海上去。
The British Empire came from the sea, and leave by the sea.”
Yang Guoqiang (Xinhua journalist), Farewell, Britannia

The area of Hong Kong was incorporated into China during the Qin Dynasty in 214 BC. In 1841, Great Britain defeated China's then-ruling Qing Dynasty in the First Opium War, gaining possession of Hong Kong Island. After the defeat of China in the Second Opium War, the Kowloon Peninsula was ceded to Great Britain in 1860. The Opium War Museum is located across the border in Dongguan. The New Territories were leased to Great Britain in 1898 for a term of 99 years. Hong Kong was only a sparsely-populated backwater prior to the arrival of the British, but grew rapidly into one of the world's most densely populated areas following the establishment of a free port under British colonial rule.

When World War II broke out, British Prime Minister Winston Churchill declared that Hong Kong was an "impregnable fortress". However owing to Britain's main war effort in Europe, Hong Kong was not given sufficient resources for its defence. After two weeks of fighting, Hong Kong was surrendered to the Japanese on 25 December 1941, and subject to a brutal occupation that lasted until the end of the war. Upon the resumption of British control, Hong Kong experienced an astonishingly swift post-war recovery.

After the communists took control of mainland China in 1949, many Chinese people, especially businessmen, fled to Hong Kong to escape persecution by the government. The British government took a hands-off approach in Hong Kong, and allowed a high degree of economic freedom. Social problems persisted during the 1950s and 1960s, including the continuation of Communist-Nationalist conflict among residents, labour disputes, and widespread corruption. These problems, when combined with effects of the Cultural Revolution, culminated in the 1967 riots by communists, with an aim to overthrow the British administration. The riots were eventually suppressed by the authorities, but they forced the colonial government to take measures of reform, such as cracking down on corruption.

Under reforms, businesses flourished in Hong Kong and its economy grew rapidly, earning it a place as one of the East Asian Tigers. Today, Hong Kong is an industrialised and developed economy, and is one of the world's most important financial centres.

In 1984 the Chinese and British Governments signed the Sino-British Joint Declaration, Britain agreeing to return Hong Kong to Chinese sovereignty. On 1 July 1997 Hong Kong became a special administrative region (SAR) of the People's Republic of China. As Hong Kong was the last remaining British colony with a significant population and economic importance, the handover was deemed by many to be the "end of empire". In theory, Hong Kong enjoys autonomy in most matters except foreign affairs and defence.

In 2014, the Umbrella Protest was held to demand free elections for Hong Kong's chief executive. The Chinese government had proposed elections for the position, but would only allow candidates they had vetted to stand for election. The proposed amendments to the Basic Law (Hong Kong's equivalent of a constitution) were voted down by the pro-democracy legislators, meaning that the chief executive is still elected by an election committee with limited representation. The protests eventually died down without concessions from China, though there remain demands for more political autonomy, and even for independence from China.



Boundary Stone along the Victoria City Boundary at Old Peak Road

Simmering tensions eventually led to the breakout of massive and violent protests in June 2019. The protests began in opposition to a bill that would have allowed people to be extradited to mainland China to face criminal charges, but expanded into a wider anti-government movement, and continued even after the extradition bill was withdrawn. In response, the Chinese government imposed a sweeping national security law on Hong Kong in July 2020, outlawing many forms of speech and advocacy against the government. This crackdown has led to a massive brain drain, with many well-educated young professionals fleeing to Western countries, in particular the United Kingdom and Canada.

Hong Kong participates in some international organisations such as the WTO and APEC, and in international sports competitions under the name "Hong Kong, China" (中國香港).

Orientation

Hong Kong Island (香港島) is the place that many tourists regard as the main focus. The parade of buildings that make the Hong Kong skyline has been likened to a glittering bar chart over the waters of Victoria Harbour. To get the best views of Hong Kong, leave the island and head for the Kowloon waterfront opposite.

The great majority of Hong Kong Island's urban development is densely packed on reclaimed land along the northern shore. This is the place to start if you are looking for evidence of the territory's colonial past. **Central** (中環) (formerly Victoria) is where you will find the machinery of government grinding away much as it always has done, except that Beijing, not London, is the boss that keeps a watchful eye. Seek a glimpse of Government House (香港禮賓府), which had been home to 25 British governors, and is now the official residence of the Chief Executive. Nearby, the Legislative Council (LegCo) continues to make the laws that govern the territory.



View from Tsim Sha Tsui

Rising up from Central is the Escalator and the Peak Tram. The famous 800-metre escalator passes through the hip district of **Soho** (蘇豪) and takes you into the residential neighbourhood known as the **Mid-Levels** (半山區) because it is half-way up the mountain. Up top is **Victoria Peak** (太平山), the tallest point on the island, where foreign diplomats and business tycoons

compete for the best views of the harbour from some of the most expensive homes to be found anywhere. Most tourists do not go much further than the Peak Tram, but take a short walk to the top and you will escape the crowds and be rewarded with some of the best harbour views. It is worth investing in a good map from a bookshop in Central if you want to enjoy some of the superb footpaths that crisscross the island.

The **southern side** of the island has developed into an upmarket residential area with many large houses and expensive apartments with views across the South China Sea. The island's best beaches, such as Repulse Bay, are found here and visitors can enjoy a more relaxed pace of life than on the bustling harbour side of the island. Wan Chai and Causeway Bay are the most visited neighbourhoods on the **northern side** of the island.

Kowloon (九龍) is the peninsula to the north of Hong Kong Island. With over 2.1 million people living in an area of less than 47 km², Kowloon is one of the most densely populated places on the planet, and has a matching array of places to shop, eat and sleep. **Tsim Sha Tsui** (尖沙咀), the tip of the peninsula, is Kowloon's main tourist drag and has a mix of backpacker and high-end hotels. Further north, **Mong Kok** (旺角) has a huge choice of shops and markets in an area of less than a square kilometre. *Kowloon side*, as it's often known, managed to escape some of the British influences that characterise the *Hong Kong Island side*. Kowloon real estate prices are the highest in the world, with multiple flats in West Kowloon setting world records with their multi-million dollar prices thanks to their panoramic views of Victoria Harbour.

The **New Territories** (新界), so named when the British leased more land from China in 1898, lie north of Kowloon. Largely rural and often ignored by travellers who have little time to spare, the New Territories offers a diverse landscape that takes time to get to know. Mountainous country parks overlook New Towns that have a clinical form of modernity that has attracted many to move here. Public transport and taxis make this offbeat place surprisingly accessible. You will not find many idyllic villages, but once you get over the stray dogs and the ramshackle buildings you will doubtlessly find something that will surprise you and cause you to reach for your camera.

The **Outlying Islands** (離島) are the islands (236 of them), islets and rocks in the seas around the territory. **Lantau** (大嶼山) is by far the largest of them and often considered its own district. The Hong Kong International Airport is built on landfill attached to Lantau. Lantau hosts some of the territory's most idyllic beaches, and major attractions such as Disneyland and the Ngong Ping cable car. Other islands include Lamma (南丫島), well known for its seafood, and Cheung Chau (長洲), a small island that used to be a pirates' den, but now attracts seafood aficionados, windsurfers and sunbathing day trippers.

People

The majority of Hong Kong's population are Han Chinese (92%), mostly of Cantonese ancestry, though there are also sizeable numbers of other Chinese groups such as Chiuchao (Teochews), Shanghainese and Hakkas. A significant number of Indians, Pakistanis and Nepalis live here too; some are immigrants, though many have families that have lived in Hong Kong for several generations. White people, some of them expatriates, and some descended from British colonists, make up just under 1% of the population. Other smaller communities whose presence in Hong Kong dates back to colonial times include the Parsis and the Baghdadi Jews.

Hong Kong has a significant minority of *Permanent Residents* who are not PRC citizens, and are not ethnically Chinese, but are recognised as Hong Kong residents by the Basic Law. This includes descendants of British, Jewish and South Asian populations from the colonial era. They are eligible to apply for Chinese citizenship, but few have taken up this option.

The largest groups of non-Chinese immigrants are Filipinos, Indonesians and Thais, most of whom are employed as domestic helpers. On Sundays, being their day off, they congregate in their thousands — mostly Filipinas — in Central and Admiralty and spend the day there together, sitting talking, eating and drinking wherever there is free room. The territory is also home to a significant number of people hailing from Australia, Europe, Japan and North America, making it a truly international metropolis.

Due to its history as part of that region, the local culture in Hong Kong is similar to that of Guangdong province. With over a century of British rule, the British have also left their mark, as have the other non-Chinese minorities who came here during the colonial period. As the city escaped the upheaval of the Cultural Revolution, Hong Kongers have maintained some aspects of traditional Chinese culture which have largely disappeared in the mainland.

Hong Kong has significant cultural differences from mainland China due to its heritage. The bulk of the population are descendants of ethnic Chinese who fled China and found safety in Hong Kong during the colonial era. Locals in Hong Kong have maintained many aspects of traditional Chinese culture that have been abandoned in the mainland, including religion, holidays, music, traditional writing and the official use of a regional language (Cantonese). British influences have also been incorporated into the local culture.

Contemporary Hong Kong is, for the most part, rather secular in daily life. The Chinese majority generally practises a mix of traditional Chinese folk religions and Buddhism. There are Hindus and Muslims, most of whom are South Asians. Christianity is followed by 10% of the population. Protestants in Hong Kong tend to be strongly conservative.

Since 1997, some policy changes have allowed a very large number of mainland citizens to visit or to move to Hong Kong (in addition to imported workers) – many fewer were allowed before the handover.

Politics

Under the "One Country, Two Systems" arrangement, Hong Kong largely retains its governmental structure from colonial times, with separate executive, legislative and judicial branches.

The head of the executive branch is the chief executive, who leads an Executive Council composed of various cabinet secretaries. The legislative branch is the Legislative Council. The Court of Final Appeal,



Hong Kong skyline at night



which is led by the Chief Justice, tops the judicial branch. Hong Kong retains a legal system based on English common law, as opposed to the civil law system used in Mainland China, Macau and Taiwan.

Both the chief executive and 70 members of the legislature are elected by interest groups that are largely stacked with pro-Beijing loyalists. 20 members of the legislature are elected by popular vote, but nominations must be approved. The central government in Beijing is therefore effectively in control of the executive and legislative branches.

Climate

Hong Kong has a humid subtropical climate. Summers are usually hot and humid, lasting from June to September, with average highs of 32 °C (90 °F) and lows of 27 °C (81 °F). Some particularly hot days can see summer temperatures climb upwards to 34 °C (93 °F) and 29 °C (84 °F) at night. The humidity can make the summer temperatures feel much hotter, the apparent feels like temperature is typically around 38 °C (100 °F) during the day and 31 °C (88 °F) at night, but cases of extreme humidity and heat can make it feel like 46 °C (115 °F) and 38 °C (100 °F) at night. Such high feels like temperatures only need an air temperature of 36 °C (97 °F) with a dew point of 27 °C (81 °F).

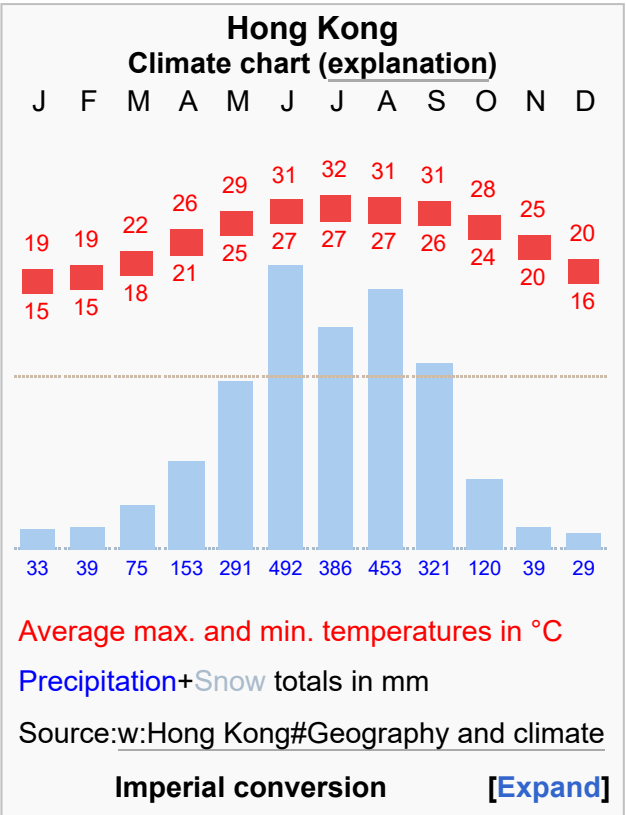
The area, like most of southern China, is affected by typhoons, which usually occur between June and September, sometimes as late as October. They seldom halt local business for more than a day.

Winters in Hong Kong are generally very mild, with temperatures usually in the range 10–20 °C (50–68 °F). Christmas in Hong Kong is warm compared to European countries. Chinese New Year is notorious for cold wet weather, because winter in Hong Kong tends to start out mild and dry and then turn cooler and wetter later.

Spring in Hong Kong is from March to May and autumn is from September to November with an average temperature of around 20–25 °C (68–77 °F). Autumn is considered a more comfortable season as spring tends to be more humid and rainy.

Although most buildings in Hong Kong have air conditioning to cope with the summer weather, winter heating is less common. During the coldest days, most locals wear more layers, even indoors. Some larger Chinese restaurants keep the air conditioning on during winter, though the temperature in air conditioned shopping malls stays the same regardless of season or weather outside.

Holidays and festivals



- **Halloween** (萬聖節). Halloween has grown rapidly in popularity, and many people dress up and party till late in the bars and nightclubs. Trick or treating is not common but most restaurants and shopping centres are decorated and have special programmes. For young adults and teenagers, Ocean Park and Disneyland are the places to be.
- **Christmas** (聖誕節). Christmas is celebrated Hong Kong style. The city is adorned using traditional Western decorations. Many shopping centres offer ample opportunities for children to meet Santa. Most shops and restaurants remain open. Higher-end restaurants will often have special Christmas meals, and these tend to book out way in advance. You should expect large crowds out shopping for the sales.
- **New Year's Eve** (元旦除夕). Hundreds of thousands of people go out on the streets to celebrate the New Year. There are all-night services on the MTR, night-buses, and many taxis. Fireworks go off on the harbour front, attracting large crowds on both sides: Tsim Sha Tsui (Kowloon side) and Central (Hong Kong Island). The party hot-spots are Causeway Bay, Lan Kwai Fong and Tsim Sha Tsui. Many people dress up and attend private parties and others flock to the streets.
- **Chinese (Lunar) New Year** (農曆新年). The most important festival for locals in Hong Kong. Many shops and restaurants close for the first 3-14 days. However, some department stores, supermarkets, and Western fast-food restaurants may remain open. The week or two leading up to the Chinese New Year, and the period from the 4th to the 15th day are good times to soak up the festive mood and celebratory events such as lion dances, fireworks, and parades.
- **Spring Lantern Festival** (正月十五/元宵節). This traditional Chinese festival in Victoria Park in Causeway Bay displays beautiful lanterns.
- **Ching Ming Festival** (清明節). This festival in spring is also known as grave sweeping day. To show respect to the deceased, family members go to the grave of their ancestors to remove weeds and leaves around the grave area. Paper offerings such as fake money are also burned despite the Environmental Protection Department's disapproval.
- **Cheung Chau Bun Festival** (長洲太平清醮). This festival on the tiny island of Cheung Chau features competitions with people climbing bun towers to snatch buns.
- **Tuen Ng Festival** (端午節). This is a festival in memory of a national hero from the Spring and Autumn Period of Chinese history. Dragon boat races are typically held and glutinous rice dumplings, usually with pork fillings, are eaten by many.

Lunar New Year dates

The year of the *Horse* began on 3 Feb 2026 at 11:58 CST , and the Lunar New Year was on 17 Feb 2026.

- The year of the *Goat* will begin on 4 Feb 2027 at 1:46 CST, and the Lunar New Year will be on 6 Feb 2027.
- The year of the *Monkey* will begin on 4 Feb 2028 at 5:09 CST, and the Lunar New Year will be on 26 Jan 2028.

Contrary to popular belief, the change of the zodiac does not occur on the first day of the Lunar New Year, but instead occurs on Li Chun (立春 *lì chūn*), the traditional Chinese start of spring.



Dragon Boat on the beach at Silver Mine Bay, Mui Wo, Lantau Island, Hong Kong



Dragon Boat Racing, Tuen Ng Festival

- **Tin Hau Festival** (天后誕). Celebrates the birthday of Tin Hau (Mandarin: Mazu 媽祖), a traditional Chinese goddess popular among fishermen and sailors. Celebrations are held in the many Tin Hau temples throughout Hong Kong.
- **Hungry Ghost Festival** (鬼節/盂蘭節). This festival runs throughout the seventh month of the Chinese calendar. It is believed that the gates of hell open during this period and hungry ghosts are allowed to roam freely into our world. People perform various rites to appease the wandering ghosts. You can also see traditional performances such as Chinese opera which are held to appease these ghosts.
- **Mid-Autumn Festival/Moon Festival** (中秋節). This festival is celebrated on the fifteenth day of the eighth lunar month. Moon cakes which contain lotus seed paste and duck egg yolks are a popular delicacy. There is also an ice-cream version. Parts of Hong Kong will be festooned with decorative lanterns which set the night scene ablaze with colour.
- **Chung Yeung Festival** (重陽節). It is a day also known as Autumn Remembrance, which is similar to Ching Ming in spring, where families visit the graves of their ancestors to perform cleansing rites and pay their respects. As the weather cools down during this part of the year, it is a good time for hiking.



Lion dancing: a dramatic spectacle at Chinese New Year. □

Events

- **Hong Kong Rugby Sevens** (<https://www.hksevens.com>). This annual event brings many visitors from around the world to celebrate the most entertaining installment in the IRB Sevens Series. It is a giant three-day sell-out event that takes place between the last days of March and the beginning of April.
- **Hong Kong Summer Spectacular**. Dragon Boat Race, music festivals, summer sales, as well as book exhibitions, Anime Fair, all in the hottest summer parties and coolest carnival.
- **Hong Kong Summer Pop Music Festival** Every summer, the Hong Kong Summer Pop Music Festival gathers top musicians who bring spectacular performances.
- **Hong Kong Arts Festival**, a month-long festival of international performances, is held in February and March.
- **Man Literary Festival**, a two-week English language festival with international writers as guests, is held in March.
- **Hong Kong International Film Festival**, a three-week event, is held in late March to early April.

Units of measure

Hong Kong's official system of measurement is metric, but both the traditional Chinese and British Imperial systems of measurements survive to some extent. In particular, the traditional Chinese system of weights continues to be widely used in wet markets, while the British square foot (平方呎/呎) is widely used in real estate advertisements.

While mainland China metricated traditional Chinese units, Hong Kong continues to use the traditional versions of those units, meaning that one *jīn* (斤, *gān* in Cantonese) is 604.8 g in Hong Kong, not 500g like in mainland China. While the *jīn* is now divided into 10 *liǎng* (兩),

léuhng in Cantonese) in mainland China, it is still divided into 16 *liǎng* in Hong Kong, meaning that the Hong Kong *liǎng* is 37.8 g, and not 50g. Public weighing scales in wet markets are required by law to display traditional Chinese, British Imperial and metric units side by side.

Read and watch

Its quick rise as an economic power and unique mix of East and West has made Hong Kong an interesting destination to write about.

- *Myself a Mandarin* (Oxford in Asia), Austin Coates. These memoirs are entertaining episodes of the Englishman's time as a colonial magistrate.
- *East and West: China, Power, and the Future of Asia* (Macmillan, 1998), Chris Patten. The last British governor of Hong Kong, provides his account of the final years before the handover to China.
- *Gweilo: Memories of a Hong Kong Childhood* (Bantam Books), Martin Booth. An insight into colonial life in Hong Kong through the eyes of a young English boy.
- *Hong Kong: Epilogue to an Empire* (Penguin Books), Jan Morris. A detailed overview of the territory's history with descriptions of its geography, economy, politics and society.
- *The World of Suzie Wong* (Fontana Press) Richard Mason. A classic novel that is the fictional story of a young expat's romance with a Chinese woman.
- *Hong Kong Landscapes: Shaping the Barren Rock* (Hong Kong University Press), Bernie Owen and Raynor Shaw. Beautifully illustrated, this is a fascinating guide to the territory's geology and geomorphology.
- *Chungking Express*, 1994, Wong Kar-wai. The unrelated stories of two love-struck cops in Hong Kong with colourful and fast cinematography.
- *The World of Suzie Wong*, 1960. A film based on the novel by Richard Mason, it is the fictional story of an expat's affair with a Chinese woman. The film has interesting footage of Hong Kong in the late 1950s.

Visitor information

- Discover Hong Kong website (<https://www.discoverhongkong.com/>)

Talk

See also: [Cantonese phrasebook](#)

The official languages of Hong Kong Special Administrative Region are **Chinese** and **English**. However, the variety (dialect) is not determined in Basic Law article 9.

Cantonese is the main language spoken by local Chinese residents. The Hong Kong variant is mostly the same as in Guangzhou across the border, but tends to incorporate some English words and slang, which frequently sounds strange to other Cantonese speakers (like "我唔sure得唔得", means "I am not sure if it's okay"). News broadcasts are in standard Cantonese.

Like all Chinese languages, Cantonese is a tonal language and not easy for foreigners to master, although learning a few simple greetings will get you acquainted with locals much more easily. Most locals have no idea how to read Romanised Cantonese, so stick to Chinese characters for written communication.

English is a common second language, and is spoken fluently by most white-collar professionals and business people. However, English proficiency tends to be more limited among the average working class person, particularly outside the main tourist areas. While many people can understand written English pretty well, they may not necessarily be comfortable speaking it.

All officials in Hong Kong must speak English. Anglophone visitors will not be in trouble to communicate in the government. In hospitals, courts, police stations are same.

There are three terrestrial English language TV stations: TVB Pearl, ViuTVsix, and HKIBC. English-language films in cinemas are almost always shown with the original soundtrack and Chinese subtitles, though children's films, especially animations, are often dubbed into Cantonese. English in Hong Kong generally follows British spelling and vocabulary choices.

English street names are seldom used among local people and taxi drivers. Even a local who speaks English fluently may not know the English name. Before you go anywhere, ask hotel staff to write down the street names using Chinese characters.

Most locals are not fluent in **Mandarin**, but can understand it to some degree. Mandarin has been compulsory in all government schools since the handover, and with the huge influx of mainland tourists, people in the tourist industry will often speak Mandarin. Most shops in the main tourist areas, as well as all government offices, will have Mandarin-speaking staff on duty. The use of Mandarin is a touchy issue, and some locals may refuse to speak Mandarin for political reasons. Even locals who speak Mandarin usually have a better command of English. If you don't speak Cantonese, it's generally better to try English first.

All official signs are bilingual in Chinese and English.

Hong Kong continues to use traditional Chinese characters, and not the simplified Chinese characters used in the mainland. Hong Kong may use simplified form for tourists or in quick hand-writing.

Some of Hong Kong's older residents may speak other dialects such as Hakka, Teochew and Shanghainese, but they are generally able to speak Cantonese as well. You may also hear other languages among Hong Kong's non-Chinese minorities, but people in these groups generally know English, and often Cantonese as well.

Hong Kong's Basic Law states that both English and Chinese are the official languages of Hong Kong. The definition of what the Chinese language actually is, however, is not clear and is rather political. People with a strong local identity would say it is Cantonese, a language in its own right, whereas people with a stronger sense of Chinese nationalism would say it is Standard Chinese (Mandarin), with Cantonese being just a local dialect. In practice, Cantonese remains the dominant language and the medium of instruction in local schools, though Mandarin is making inroads.

唔該; *m' goi*

Just one Cantonese word that will go a very long way in and around Hong Kong. Learn this word and you can use it to say please, thank you and excuse me. Mh'gōi rhymes with boy and should be said with a cheery high tone rising at the end. Give it a go.

Hong Kong has a large amount of non-Chinese population. Many South Asians live in Hong Kong. They may speak Hindi, Urdu, Vietnamese, Punjabi, Indonesian, or Thai, et al.

Hong Kong Sign Language (HKSL, 香港手語) is the language of the deaf community. It is mutually intelligible with Macau Sign Language, and more distantly related to Chinese Sign Language used in the mainland, not mutually intelligible with it.

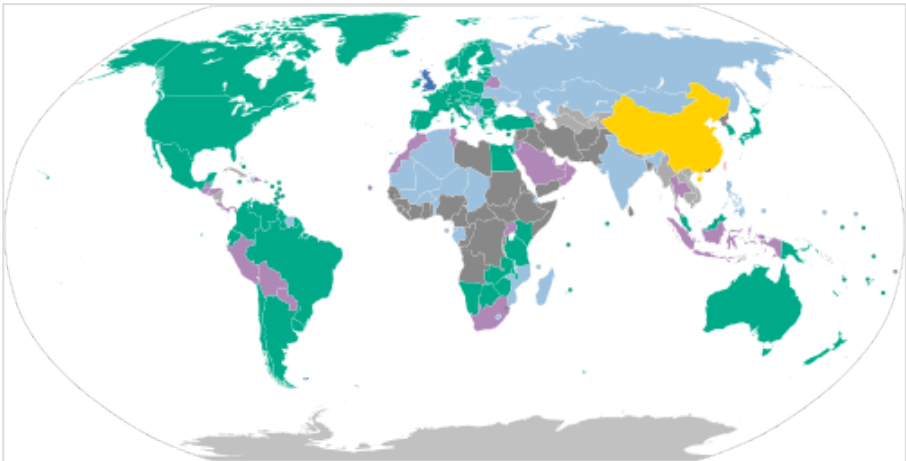


A bilingual sign. "Single track road with passing place"

Get in

Immigration

Hong Kong maintains a separate immigration system from that of Mainland China. Citizens of most Western countries do not need a visa to visit Hong Kong. The Hong Kong visa can be applied for at a Chinese diplomatic mission, but must be done so separately from the Mainland Chinese one; there is no single visa that serves both areas. A visa is required to enter Mainland China from Hong Kong and vice versa. Macau is also a separate jurisdiction with regards to visas. If you wish to re-enter Mainland China after visiting Hong Kong, make sure you have a multiple-entry Chinese visa.



Visa policy of Hong Kong

- Hong Kong
- May enter with Entry-Exit Permit for Hong Kong SAR or Macau SAR - Varies
- May enter with Mainland Travel Permit for Taiwan Residents - 30 days
- Visa-free - 180 days
- Visa-free - 90 days
- Visa-free - 30 days
- Visa-free - 14 days (India with online pre-registration)
- Visa-free - 7 days
- Visa required in advance

See Entry requirements to Hong Kong (<https://www.immd.gov.hk/eng/services/visas/visit-transit/visit-visa-entry-permit.html>) for a list of visa requirements or visa-free stays by country of citizenship. All holders of an APEC Business Travel Card can use the counters for Hong Kong residents at immigration control and can stay for up to 60 days in Hong Kong visa-free if their card has 'HKG' printed on the reverse.

Foreign nationals who cannot enter visa-free, want to remain for longer than permitted by their visa exemption, or want to work, study or establish/join a business, can apply for one at a Chinese embassy or consulate, or directly through the Hong Kong Immigration Department (<http://www.imd.gov.hk>)

[ps://www.immd.gov.hk/eng/services/visas/visit_transit.html](https://www.immd.gov.hk/eng/services/visas/visit_transit.html)). Those living in Macau can apply for a visa at the Office of the Commissioner of the Chinese Foreign Ministry (<http://www.fmco-prc.gov.mo/>). Those living in Mainland China may apply at the Hong Kong Economic and Trade Office (<https://www.sheto.gov.hk/>) in Shanghai, or at the Office of the Government of the Hong Kong SAR (<https://www.bjo.gov.hk/>) in Beijing.

Mainland Chinese citizens who reside in the mainland must obtain a card-styled entry permit (<https://www.immd.gov.hk/en/services/hk-visas/overseas-chinese-entry-arrangement/overseas-chinese.html#18>) (往來港澳通行證). They cannot use their passports to enter Hong Kong unless they are in transit to/from a foreign country. Mainland Chinese citizens may use their passport or Taiwan Travel Permit (往來台灣通行證) to transit through Hong Kong, in which case they may visit for up to seven days. Mainland Chinese citizens who reside overseas may also apply for an Entry Permit of Hong Kong Special Administrative Region at a Chinese diplomatic mission, and use their passport with such an entry permit to enter Hong Kong.



An Entry Permit of Hong Kong Special Administrative Region

Holders of Macau *permanent* identity cards or Visit Permits with *permanent* resident status can enter Hong Kong visa-free for up to 180 days. Holders of Macao Visit Permits *without* permanent resident status can enter Hong Kong visa-free for up to 30 days. See Visit/Transit Arrangements to Hong Kong for Macao Residents (<https://www.immd.gov.hk/eng/services/visas/overseas-chinese-entry-arrangement.html#b>) for more details. Though they can be used when leaving Macau, Macau digital identity cards are *not* accepted by Hong Kong immigration, and the physical one must be presented when entering Hong Kong.

Citizens of Taiwan are granted visa-free access to Hong Kong for 30 days if they have a Mainland Travel Permit/Taiwan Compatriot Pass (*Taibaozheng*, 台胞證). Otherwise, a pre-arrival registration is required which can be applied for through the Immigration Department (https://www.immd.gov.hk/eng/services/visas/pre-arrival_registration_for_taiwan_residents.html). See Arrangements for Entry to Hong Kong for Overseas Chinese and Chinese residents of Taiwan (<https://www.immd.gov.hk/eng/services/visas/overseas-chinese-entry-arrangement.html#c>) for more details. "Chinese residents of Taiwan" refers to citizens of Taiwan.

Holders of British National (Overseas) (BNO) passports cannot use these passports to enter Hong Kong and should instead use their Hong Kong passport, Hong Kong ID card, or Hong Kong document of identity when passing immigration and during their stay in Hong Kong.

Indian nationals do not require a visa, however they need to submit a pre-arrival registration (PAR) form (https://www.immd.gov.hk/eng/services/visas/pre-arrival_registration_for_indian_nationals.html). The PAR is valid for six months from date of issue / registration and allows for multiple entries during the validity period, each for a maximum of 14 days. A visit to Macau and back shall be considered a new entry and restarts the 14 day clock. However visitors may be subject to enquiries by the immigration officials during the re-entry about the purpose & reason for re-entry.

Expiry of the limit of stay is counted from the day after the date of entry. For example, if you have a 7-day visa and arrive on January 1, you are allowed to stay until January 8. If you are arriving late at night, you may want to wait until after midnight to clear immigration. Likewise, you may be able to clear immigration just before midnight on the last day that your visa is valid and then take a flight or boat in the middle of the night on the next day. For more information, see question #11 of the [Visa FAQs \(https://www.immd.gov.hk/en/faq/visit-transit.html\)](https://www.immd.gov.hk/en/faq/visit-transit.html).

Hong Kong no longer issues passport stamps, and visitors are instead given an entry slip with their terms of entry. All entries and exits are recorded electronically as well. You do not need to fill out a paper or digital arrival card.

Citizens of [Afghanistan](#), [Angola](#), [Bangladesh](#), [Burundi](#), [Cameroon](#), [Central African Republic](#), [Cote d'Ivoire](#), [Democratic Republic of the Congo](#), [Eritrea](#), [Eswatini](#), [Ethiopia](#), [Gambia](#), [Ghana](#), [Guinea-Bissau](#), [Iran](#), [Iraq](#), [Liberia](#), [Libya](#), [Nepal](#), [Nigeria](#), [North Korea](#), [Pakistan](#), [Republic of the Congo](#), [Rwanda](#), [Sierra Leone](#), [Somalia](#), [South Sudan](#), [Sri Lanka](#), [Sudan](#), [Syria](#), [Togo](#), and [Yemen](#) are *required to obtain a transit visa* even for sterile transit through Hong Kong International Airport.

e-Channel

Regular visitors can register to use the **e-Channel (<https://www.gov.hk/en/residents/immigration/control/echannel.htm#fvapc>)** to avoid the queues by going through an automated barrier which uses fingerprint recognition technology. You may be eligible to use e-Channel if you are a Macau resident, are a mainland Chinese citizen holding a valid entry permit, or have a biometric passport issued by [Australia](#), [Germany](#), [Singapore](#), [South Korea](#) or [Thailand](#), and have visited Hong Kong at least twice in the past 24 months. You can also enroll on the basis of membership in some frequent flyer programmes (some of which require you to possess status in their upper tiers).

Hong Kong permanent residents can use e-Channels labelled for visitors if the gates for permanent residents are congested.

Customs

If you are carrying goods that are **banned** or **more than your allowance**, you *must* declare them at the Red Channel when you enter Hong Kong — even when travelling from Mainland China, Macau or Taiwan:

- Meat and eggs, animal products, fish, rice (exceeding 15 kg)
- Ozone depleting substances, items with forged trade marks, radio communication transmitting apparatus
- Smokeless tobacco, e-cigarettes, and herbal cigarettes

[Cannabidiol \(CBD\)](#) is banned in Hong Kong. Offenders face a maximum penalty of life imprisonment.

Pepper sprays and tasers are prohibited in Hong Kong even for transit visitors — while first-time offenders might receive a warning or fine (and the items confiscated), authorities can still charge you for unlawful possession of arms, a serious offence punishable for 14 years imprisonment.

A traveller aged 18 or above is allowed to bring into Hong Kong – *for their own use* – as part of their duty-free allowance:

- 1 litre of alcoholic liquor with an alcoholic strength above 30% by volume measured at a temperature of 20 °C
- 19 cigarettes *or* 1 cigar *or* 25 g of cigars *or* 25 g of other manufactured tobacco
 - If the traveller holds a Hong Kong Identity Card, they must have spent 24 hours or longer outside Hong Kong to benefit from the duty-free allowance relating to alcoholic liquor.

The Hong Kong government restricts the amount of **baby formula** that may be taken out of the territory to no more than 1.8 kg. Violation of this restriction could lead to fines and imprisonment.

For more information, visit the [Hong Kong Customs and Excise Department website \(https://www.customs.gov.hk\)](https://www.customs.gov.hk).

By plane

Hong Kong International Airport

Main article: [Hong Kong International Airport](#)

Hong Kong International Airport (**HKG** ^{IATA}), also known as Chek Lap Kok (赤鱲角), is on Lantau Island in the west of Hong Kong. The Airport Express train is the fastest and most comfortable way into town, but there are also numerous bus lines and taxis. See [the article](#) for more about the airport.



Dropoff area of Hong Kong International Airport



Shenzhen International Airport

As flights between Hong Kong and mainland China are treated as international flights, it is often cheaper to fly to [Shenzhen Airport \(https://www.szairport.com/szairport/en/index.shtml\)](https://www.szairport.com/szairport/en/index.shtml) (**SZX** ^{IATA}), in the nearby mainland Chinese city of [Shenzhen](#).

To travel between Shenzhen Airport and Hong Kong:

- Direct buses operate between the airport and the [Elements Shopping Mall \(http://www.elementshk.com/eng/elements/tourist/index.jsp\)](http://www.elementshk.com/eng/elements/tourist/index.jsp), above the Kowloon MTR station. You can check-in and receive your boarding pass (except for China Southern Airlines passengers) at the check-in desk on the 1st floor of the shopping centre, opposite Starbucks. This in-town check-in is completely separate from the in-town check-in provided for Hong Kong International Airport. The cost of the service is \$100 and the bus is advertised to take 75 minutes, but it usually takes 100 minutes. Buses run every 30 minutes from 6:30AM to 7PM from Hong Kong and from 10AM to 9PM from Shenzhen.
- From Fuyong Ferry Terminal at Shenzhen Airport one can buy ferry tickets to Hong Kong. Passengers who need to transfer between flights at Hong Kong and Shenzhen airports can use the ferry service to/from Hong Kong airport without having to pass through Hong Kong immigration.
- A *cheaper* way is to take Shenzhen Metro Line **11** from the airport to Futian in central Shenzhen (29 minutes, ¥7). From here, you can connect to the High Speed Rail direct to

West Kowloon in downtown Hong Kong (15 minutes, \$80). Even cheaper is taking Shenzhen Metro Line **10** to "Futian Checkpoint" (10 minutes, ¥2) (called Lok Ma Chau on the Hong Kong side) or Shenzhen Metro Line **1** to "Luohu" (20 minutes, ¥4) (Lo Wu on the Hong Kong side), then pass through a long corridor and an international border gate (have visa ready) and once in Hong Kong, hop on the **East** Rail suburban rail line to central Hong Kong (45 minutes, \$35).

Guangzhou Baiyun International Airport

Guangzhou Baiyun International Airport is a bit further away than Shenzhen, but has more flights and with direct coach connections to Hong Kong.

Macau International Airport

It is also often cheaper to fly into Macau International Airport (<https://www.macau-airport.com/en>) (**MFH** ^{IATA}). Air Asia (<https://www.airasia.com/en/gb>) has a hub at Macau from where it operates service to Kuala Lumpur, Bangkok, and Chiang Mai, among other cities.

To travel between Macau Airport and Hong Kong:

- With the Express Link (<https://www.macau-airport.com/en/transportation/express-link-service>) service, you can transfer directly from airport to ferry (or vice versa) without going through Macau immigration. \$70 from Hong Kong (with baggage being checked in there) or \$50 to Hong Kong, excluding the ferry ticket cost.
- If you don't need a visa for Macau, the cheaper way is to clear Macau immigration and to go yourself to Macau Taipa Ferry Terminal just to the north from the airport. Outside of the airport, take a bus MT1 or 26 from "Rotunda de Aeroporto / Wai Long" bus stop, and get out at the terminal (normally the next stop). The ticket price is HK\$4.2 or MOP4.2. From the airport, it's wise to get some change before taking this bus, and both the ATMs normally dispense both Hong Kong dollars and Macanese pataca, and the local shops accept the former in lieu of the latter (at 1:1 rate). You may get coins of both currencies as a change. It would take around 20 minutes to walk to the ferry terminal. If coming from Hong Kong, choose Cotai Water Jet ferry to get to Macau Taipa Ferry Terminal.
- the AP1 bus will transport you to Macau Outer Ferry Terminal, but the bus trip will take longer as it will have to cross to the mainland part of Macau.
- Those having a few hours to spare in Macau and not much baggage may choose to take one of the buses going to one of the casinos (Venetian, Sands, etc.) waiting both near the airport and the Macau Taipa Ferry Terminal, spend some time there, then return to either ferry terminal or the airport using a similar bus. These buses are free of charge.

By helicopter

- **Sky Shuttle** (<http://www.skyshuttlehk.com/>). A helicopter service several times a day from the Terminal Marítimo in Macau to the Shun Tak Heliport (**HHP** ^{IATA}) at the Hong Kong-Macau Ferry Pier in Sheung Wan, Hong Kong Island. The trip takes 15 minutes and one-way fares cost \$4,300. (updated Jul 2024 |)

By train

See also: Rail travel in China

Multiple frequent high-speed trains connect Hong Kong with Shenzhen and Guangzhou every day, with daily long-distance trains running further afield to major cities across China such as Beijing, Shanghai, Kunming, Xi'an, Chengdu or Chongqing. MTR High Speed (<https://www.highspeed.mtr.com.hk/en/main/index.html>) runs some high-speed passenger services up to Guangzhou under the Vibrant Express brand, while CRH (the high-speed branch of China Railways) operates the remaining short-distance trains and all the long-distance ones. It takes 23 minutes from Shenzhen, 48 minutes from Guangzhou, 8½ hours from Shanghai and 8 hours 10 min from Beijing on the daytime trains. Overnight high-speed sleeper services from Shanghai and Beijing run four times a week, taking 10 h 55 min and 11 h 27 min respectively. The line runs underground in Hong Kong, so don't expect to see any sights. High-speed rail is now your only option for travelling by train directly from the mainland.

Services on this line go to the **1 West Kowloon Station**. This station is huge, although most of its footprint is underground. There is a food court (important as many shorter services don't have a dining car, including all Vibrant Express trains), as well as other facilities such as a business lounge and public waiting spaces. It is connected to Austin station on **Tuen Ma** line and Kowloon station on the **Tung Chung** and **Airport** lines, and to a bus terminal.

The station has several levels:

- **L2** - Sky Corridor
 - **L1** - Various footbridge connections
 - **G** - Station entrance, transport area, ground level
-
- **B1** - Ticketing
 - **B2** - Arrival Concourse, Parking
 - **B3** - Departure Concourse
 - **B4** - Platforms

Both Mainland and Hong Kong immigration and customs are co-located at this station. The station's Mainland Port Area is under Mainland China's jurisdiction, and is demarcated by a yellow line. When you clear immigration to board a train at West Kowloon, you are subject to Mainland Chinese law. Chinese Internet censorship doesn't apply to the Mainland Port Area, as mobile internet service is provided by Hong Kong operators.



West Kowloon station



High speed train from West Kowloon station to Guangzhou South station



Overnight sleeper train from West Kowloon station to Beijing West station

You can travel by a wider range of high-speed trains and overnight sleepers from many Chinese cities to Shenzhen, and then change to the Metro or another high-speed rail train to reach Hong Kong. Shenzhen Railway Station is adjacent to the Lo Wu/Luohu border crossing.

By ferry

Hong Kong is a one-hour **hydrofoil ride** away from Macau and there are also good connections from mainland China. If you plan to only visit Zhuhai, a visa-on-arrival is available at Jiuzhou Ferry Terminal for up to 3 days. The main terminals are:

- **2 Hong Kong-Macau Ferry Terminal, 202**
Connaught Rd (Sheung Wan MTR exit D) in Central.
 - TurboJet (<http://www.turbojet.com.hk/>), every 5–30 minutes, 24 hours a day from Macau.
 - Cotai Jet (<https://www.cotaiwaterjet.com/>), every 15–30 minutes, 24 hours a day from Taipa, Macau.
- **3 Hong Kong China Ferry Terminal, 33 Canton Rd**
(Tsim Sha Tsui MTR exit A1) in Kowloon.
 - Chu Kong Passenger Transport (<https://www.cksp.com.hk/>), from Zhuhai and various other points in mainland China's Guangdong Province.
 - TurboJet (<http://www.turbojet.com.hk/>), every 30 minutes from Macau.
 - Xunlong (<http://www.xunlongferry.com>) from Shekou in Shenzhen, mainland China.

If you're flying into Hong Kong airport to reach Macau or other cities in the Pearl River Delta, see Hong Kong International Airport for direct ferry options that skip Hong Kong immigration.

By cruise ship

4 Kai Tak Cruise Terminal is a newer terminal that opened on the site of the former Kai Tak Airport runway. The terminal supports two large ship berths. Known to be notoriously deserted with few shops, the terminal has limited access to public transportation, although there are free shuttle services to nearby shopping and public transportation when cruise ships arrive.

5 Ocean Terminal is the old cruise ship terminal in Tsim Sha Tsui, which is well connected to public transportation and shopping malls.

Check with your cruise line before you travel to find out which terminal your ship berths at.



A TurboJet catamaran



The *Star Pisces* at Ocean Terminal



Blake Pier at Stanley



By bridge

The 50-km **Hong Kong–Zhuhai–Macau Bridge (HZMB)**, a bridge and tunnel opened in October 2018, was one of the largest construction projects in the world. The link makes it possible to travel quickly across the Pearl River Delta without taking the ferry.

Frequent HZMBus (<https://www.hzmbus.com>) shuttle buses departing up to every 5 minutes, 24 hours a day are available to cross the HZMB. They take around 40 minutes, and tickets can be purchased with Octopus or AliPay from ticket machines, as well as cash and credit cards at the ticket desk at the **6 HZMB Hong Kong**

Kong Port. The Hong Kong Port can be reached by taxis or various buses including CityFlyer airport (A number) routes, or the B5 shuttle bus from Sunny Bay MTR station, or the B6 bus from Tung Chung. Once arriving at the **7 HZMB Macau Port** you can take taxis or the 101X bus, the 102X bus to St Paul's and Taipa, or the **HZMB Integrated Resort Connection** bus (free) to Taipa Ferry Terminal or the Exterior Ferry terminal to connect to the free casino shuttle buses. Once arriving at the **HZMB Zhuhai Port**, you can take taxis or the L1 bus which uses historic tourist vehicles, or the 12, 23 or 25 buses to continue your journey in the mainland.

If you are flying into Hong Kong to get to Macau or Zhuhai, see the Hong Kong International Airport article for direct coach options that skip Hong Kong immigration.

To drive across the bridge, you must apply for a permit from the mainland government if travelling to Zhuhai or three separate permits (one from each of the Hong Kong, Macau, and mainland governments) to drive to Macau.

By other land crossings

Shenzhen is the Chinese city that borders Hong Kong. See China#Get in for information on visa requirements.

There are 8 land checkpoints between Hong Kong and mainland China. Be sure to note the opening hours of the border crossing before starting your journey. If you are driving across the border, you must have a set of plates issued by each of China and Hong Kong. You will have to change sides of the road at the border because people in Hong Kong drive on the left, and people in mainland China drive on the right.

Cross-boundary coaches travel to Hong Kong from several cities in mainland China and are usually easier than crossing the border via several transfers and several modes of transportation. For information on these services, see the website of each border crossing listed below. Other than the Shenzhen Bay Bridge and the Hong Kong-Zhuhai-Macao Bridge, these crossings are within the frontier closed area, meaning it's illegal to head there without a permit unless you are crossing the border.

If you were shopping in mainland China and wish to claim a tax refund, they can only be processed at Man Kam To, Lok Ma Chau Spur Line, Lo Wu and Shenzhen Bay Bridge control points.



Shuttle buses between Hong Kong and Zhuhai/Macau

By bicycle

Cycling into Hong Kong is only permitted through **Heung Yuen Wai Control Point** (Liantang Port on the Shenzhen side). You will need to dismount your bike and walk it through the immigration hall, but there is no need to disassemble or fold it. After completing border formalities, you can continue the rest of your journey on bicycle.

You can also bring a bicycle through Hong Kong's other border crossings, but the process is more of a hassle as you will need to fold or disassemble your bike and take public transport out of the Frontier Closed Area before you can continue cycling:

- You can bring a bicycle across the border at Lo Wu Control Point (https://www.td.gov.hk/en/transport_in_hong_kong/land_based_cross_boundary_transport/access_to_lo_wu_control_point/index.html), then board the MTR East Rail train. Bicycles are allowed on the train provided the front wheel is removed. You can alight at Sheung Shui station and continue the rest of your journey by bicycle if you wish.
- You can also bring a bicycle across the border at Lok Ma Chau Spur Line Control Point (https://www.td.gov.hk/en/transport_in_hong_kong/land_based_cross_boundary_transport/access_to_lok_ma_chau_spur_line_control_point/index.html). In addition to the Lok Ma Chau MTR East Rail station, which you bring your bike onto under the same conditions as Lo Wu, it is also served by GMB minibus #75 and KMB bus #B1. Only folding bicycles are allowed on buses, provided they are folded. Once your bus leaves the Frontier Closed Area, you may alight and continue the rest of your journey by bicycle.

Get around

Hong Kong has an excellent and cheap public transport system. Unlike in mainland China, Google Maps can be used in Hong Kong.

Hong Kong has the world's highest use of public transport, with over 90% preferring the mode. The most convenient way to pay for this is the **Octopus card**, discussed below.

Contactless payments with Visa, Mastercard, UnionPay, and China T-Union are being progressively rolled out. However, as of September 2025, they're only accepted at the light blue gates of MTR stations, and are *not* available on the Airport Express, buses, trams or ferries. Most visitors are still better off buying an Octopus card.

Octopus card

The **Octopus Card** (<https://www.octopus.com.hk/en/>) (八達通, *Bat Dat Toong* in Cantonese) is a prepaid card that can be used to pay for public transportation such as the MTR, trains, trams, buses, mini-buses, and ferries. Most taxis do not yet accept it although more will in future. Paying for public transport with an Octopus Card is usually at a discounted fare (not the case though for buying a return Airport Express ticket).

It can also be used to pay for items in convenience stores, supermarkets, fast food restaurant chains, many vending machines, all roadside parking and some car parks. It can also be used as a building access card. Some chain stores, such as Wellcome, offer discounts for paying with the

Octopus Card. This is a great way to avoid carrying and counting coins.

A tourist Octopus card costs \$150 and includes \$111 in stored value plus a \$39 non-refundable deposit. It is a sold version of the card and can be purchased conveniently from the Octopus vending machine at the arrival hall of Hong Kong International Airport. The remaining balance can be refunded and the card will be disabled. The card itself can be retained by the visitor as a souvenir.

The maximum value an Octopus card can carry is \$3,000. The credit on the card can go negative. For example, you may pay for a ride costing \$5 with only \$2 of remaining value on the card (bringing the stored value to -\$3) but you cannot use the card again until the value is topped up. The value of an Octopus card can go as low as -\$35. That isn't really "negative", meaning you don't have to pay MTR back, since your \$50 deposit secures it.

Your Octopus card's balance is displayed on the reader after each use. The balance can also be checked, along with the last nine transactions, using a small machine near regular ticket machines at MTR stations.

It is simple and convenient to top up your Octopus Card:

- "Add Value" machines, usually next to regular ticket machines in MTR stations. Top-Ups in these machines can be made in multiple of \$50 and only in cash.
- Customer service centres at all MTR stations
- Some merchants that accept Octopus (e.g. 7-Eleven, McDonald's, Wellcome, etc.). This is the best way to avoid queues at the MTR station.
- **Octopus for Tourists App**

Top-ups are generally possible in multiples of \$50 only. The **Octopus for Tourists** app allows for top-up in multiples of \$1 but with a higher minimum of \$100.

A joint Octopus-China T-Union Card (<https://www.octopus.com.hk/en/consumer/octopus-cards/products/cross-border/china-t-union.html>) can be used in most major cities across China (notable exceptions include Wuhan and Hohhot).

An existing Octopus card can be added to Apple/Google Wallet, but as of 2025 there are limitations on what phones support this and it is not possible for a visitor to create a new virtual card in the app.

By Mass Transit Railway

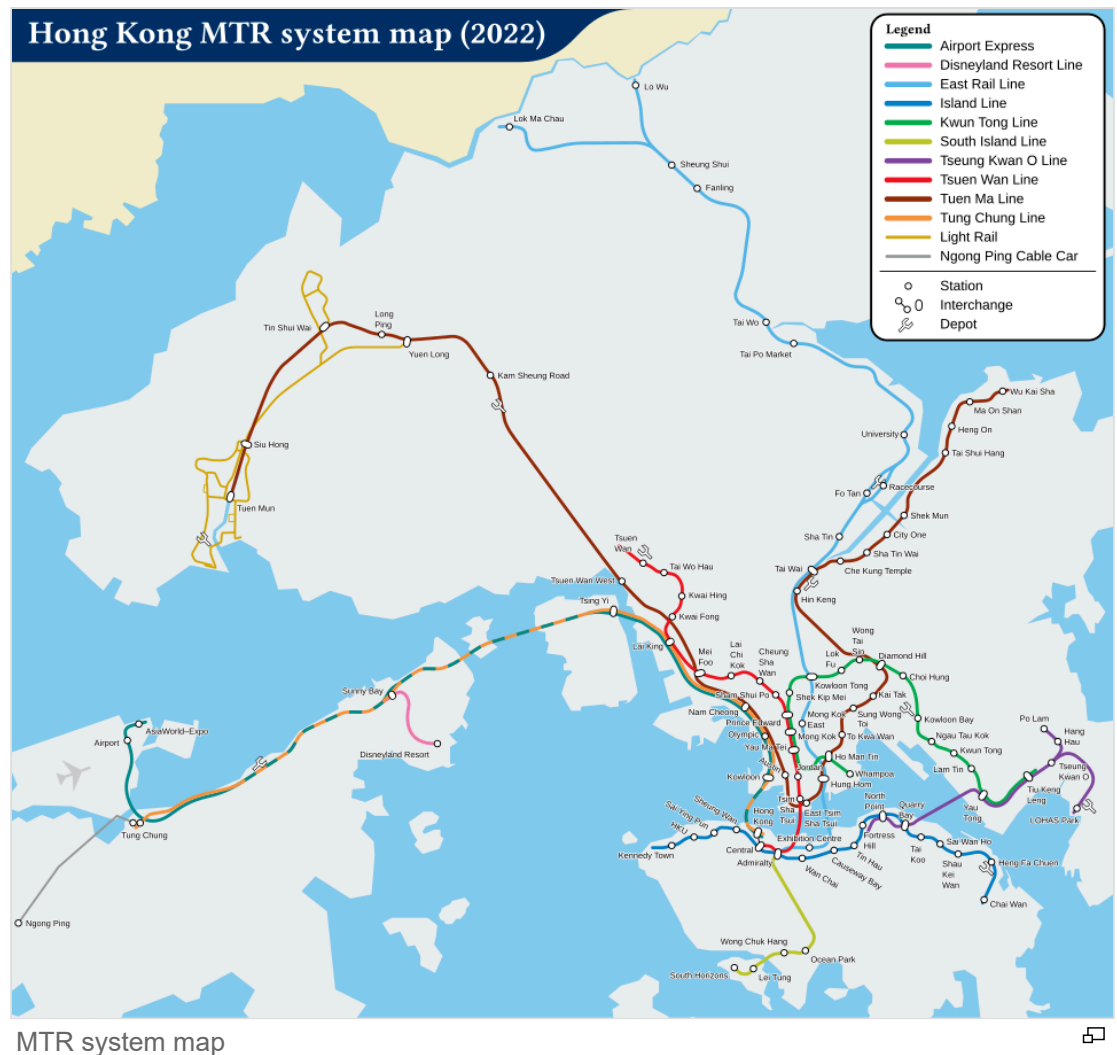
Hong Kong's Mass Transit Railway (<https://www.mtr.com.hk/>) (**MTR**) is the fastest way to get around, but it does not offer the views of buses and trams. It is clean, safe, reliable, efficient and affordable, with most journeys costing \$5-20. There are 10 lines (including the Airport Express) and a network of modern light rail lines in the Northwest New Territories. All signs are in both Chinese and English and all announcements are made in Cantonese, Mandarin, and English. Staff in the station control room usually speak enough English to be able to help lost tourists.

The most important lines for many visitors are

1. The busy **Tsuen Wan Line** (red), which runs from Central to Kowloon via tunnel and then down Nathan Road towards Tsuen Wan in the New Territories,

2. The **Island Line** (blue) which runs along the north coast of Hong Kong Island.

3. The **Tung Chung Line** (orange) is the fastest ways to get to Lantau. This line can also be used to change to the



MTR system map



Disneyland Resort Line (pink) at Sunny Bay, which is also the station to catch a shuttle bus to the Hong Kong port for those who want to travel by bus to Macau.

4. The **South Island Line** can also be used to visit Ocean Park.
5. The **East Rail Line** which takes you to New Territories and contains First Class coaches.
6. The **Airport Express** line goes directly from the Hong Kong MTR station to Hong Kong International Airport. See [#By plane](#) for details.

In Cantonese, the East Rail line is colloquially referred to as 火車 (*fó chē*, "train"), alluding to its origins as an intercity railway, while the other lines are referred to as 地鐵 (*dei tit*, "subway").

Considerations when using the MTR:

- The MTR system is linked to two **border crossings** with mainland China, at **Lo Wu Control Point** (https://www.td.gov.hk/en/transport_in_hong_kong/land_based_cross_boundary_transport/access_to_lo_wu_control_point/index.html) and **Lok Ma Chau Spur Line Control Point** (https://www.td.gov.hk/en/transport_in_hong_kong/land_based_cross_boundary_transport/access_to_lok_ma_chau_spur_line_control_point/), both on the East Rail Line. You exit the fare gates into the Hong Kong immigration hall, then cross a bridge over the Sham Chun River



A typical MTR Station entrance; its symbolic red circle icon is easily recognisable.



into the mainland Chinese immigration hall. Once you have cleared mainland Chinese immigration and customs, a station on the Shenzhen Metro is only a short walk away, and directions are well-signposted in both Chinese and English. As Lo Wu and Lok Ma Chau stations are in a restricted area, it is illegal to take the train to these stations without a permit unless you are crossing the border.

- Rides on East Rail line First Class, the Airport Express, and to/from Lo Wu/Lok Ma Chau follow a separate fare structure. MTR system promotions (including the tourist day pass, and the fare saver machines) do not extend to these services.
- The East Rail Line offers a first class car where the seats are wider and more comfortable. The fare is twice that of the regular cars on the same route, and you must buy a separate ticket at a station's ticketing office or validate your Octopus card before entering. Ticket inspectors conduct regular patrol in the carriage and *passengers without a valid first class ticket or validated Octopus card may be fined up to \$500*.
- In Hong Kong, the English name for the underground metro system is the 'MTR'. The term 'Subway' refers to underground walkways, as opposed to the metro system. 'Metro' or 'Underground' are not commonly understood by local people either.
- Fares depend on distance. Credit cards cannot be used to buy tickets on most vending machines. However you can tap contactless Visa, Mastercard or UnionPay credit cards (or Apple or Android pay devices linked to one of those) at the MTR fare gates to pay fares. Visa and Mastercard may also be used to top up Octopus cards via the Octopus for Tourists App.
- Mainland Chinese visitors can also pay fares using Alipay and WeChat Pay. Just look for a faregate that is equipped with a QR code scanner, which you can use to scan the Alipay or WeChat Pay QR code on your smart phone.
- Tsim Sha Tsui on the Tsuen Wan line and East Tsim Sha Tsui on the Tuen Ma line are considered one station for purposes of fare calculation and transfers. But to transfer from one line to the other on those stations without incurring additional costs, you must tap out from one station and tap in *within 30 minutes* to the other.
- Consumption of food and drinks and smoking are strictly forbidden in the paid area of stations and in trains. Offenders are liable to *a fine of up to \$2,000*.
- Always **stand on the right** when using escalators to allow people to pass on the left. Hong Kongers do not shove or jostle for seats as is common in mainland Chinese Metro systems.
- Disabled Access and Stroller Access is provided at the MTR stations, but you may have to walk a long way: the lift may be at one end of a platform at train level, whilst the lift to street level will be at the other end. There is usually one designated fare reader for wider (wheelchair/stroller) access, but often it is a long walk around the station or platform. Occasionally, there will be an MTR staff booth at a set of gates, but they may or may not tap your card on their terminal and let you through the goods entrance to the platform. It may be better to collapse your stroller, pick up your child and use the escalators and regular fare readers. A small, lightweight, upright folding stroller will be easier to use on transit.
- Some adjacent stations are served by the same two lines (e.g. Central and Admiralty on the Tsuen Wan and Island lines; Yau Ma Tei, Mong Kok, and Prince Edward on the Kwun Tong and Tsuen Wan lines). However some of these stations offer quicker and more convenient cross-platform interchanges than others depending on the direction of transfer. Watch the flashing system maps on the train and listen to the announcements to know which of the stations are convenient for the transfers you wish to make.

There are several **fare saver machines** (https://www.mtr.com.hk/en/customer/tickets/fare_saver.html) in shopping malls and offices around Hong Kong. By tapping your Octopus Card at the machine's reader, you will receive a \$2 discount if you walk to the indicated station and start an MTR journey there.

By tram

Operated by **Hong Kong Tramways** (<https://www.hktramways.com/>), the narrow double-decker trams (also known locally as "ding ding") trundling along the northern coast of Hong Kong Island have provided cheap transport for over a century. Riding the tram is a great and cheap way to sightsee. For an excursion lasting 1 hour, board at the **Kennedy Town Terminus** and get a good seat on the upper deck. As the tram travels eastward, you will have an elevated view of Hong Kong Island and its different flavours, from bustling Hong Kong street life to its glitzy financial and shopping districts and, finally, a taste of the local residential areas.

- Trams are not air conditioned. Summer months can be very uncomfortable even with the windows open.
- They run 6AM to midnight.
- Passengers board at the rear and a flat \$3.3 fare is paid when getting *off* at the front of the tram. The fare is paid for by Octopus Card, coins (no change given) or contactless Visa/Mastercard (including Apple Pay and Google Pay). Using a contactless Visa provides a \$1 discount. There are two readers — one for Octopus Card and the other for contactless Visa/Mastercard, so if you are using Apple Pay with both an Octopus Card and Visa/Mastercard, be careful to tap your device on the correct reader.
- It is widely used by foreign domestic workers on Sundays (their normal day-off). Trams often get crowded on these days.



Peak Tram entering Victoria Peak terminus

Peak Tram

The **Peak Tram** (<https://www.thepeak.com.hk/en>), Hong Kong's first mechanised mode of transport, opened in 1888. The remarkably steep 1.7-km track from Central up to Victoria Peak is worth at least one trip despite the comparatively steep price (\$62 one-way, \$88 return; return tickets must be purchased in advance). The tram turnstiles take Octopus cards.

The Peak Tram is likely to be crowded at night when the view of the city's skyline is magic, and on public holidays. Queues can be very long (waiting an hour is common at busy times), and a lot of pushing has been reported.

The tram is not the only way to get to the Peak, and there are cheaper (but slower and still quite scenic) alternatives such as the #1 green minibus costing \$10.2, and the #15 double-decker bus costing \$10.3 from Exchange Square Bus Terminus. These buses will often give you great views of both sides of Hong Kong Island on the way up.

Light rail

MTR operates a tram system in the northwest New Territories called **Light Rail** (https://www.mtr.com.hk/en/customer/services/more_light_rail.html). It is a modern and fast tram system connecting Tuen Mun, Yuen Long, and Tin Shui Wai. It uses a proof-of-payment fare system, in which passengers are required to buy a ticket or tap an Octopus card at the station

entrance before boarding and there are no fare gates, but ticket inspection is random. The area is seldom visited by foreign tourists but various sights are nonetheless accessible via Light Rail, such as numerous ancient walled villages (highlighted by the Ping Shan Heritage Trail), the Hong Kong Wetland Park, the beaches of Tuen Mun New Town, Yuen Long Town Centre, and seafood towns like Lau Fau Shan and Sam Shing.

By bus

There are three types of buses available in Hong Kong. In the city centre, buses will get stuck in traffic and take much longer than the MTR. However, they cover many more destinations than the MTR. While generally easy to use, signs in English can be sparse and finding your bus stop can get difficult. Buses are also the only public option in some areas. Google Maps, Apple Maps, or City Mapper (<https://citymapper.com/hong-kong>) will let you know the best bus route to take from your current position to your destination (if necessary, they will combine it with MTR rides too).

Double-decker buses are used on most routes and cover practically the entire territory, stop frequently and charge varying fares depending on the distance. The first seats of the upper deck offer great views.

The franchised bus operators in Hong Kong include Kowloon Motor Bus (<https://www.kmb.hk>) (KMB) (and its subsidiary Long Win Bus), Citybus (CTB) (<https://www.citybus.com.hk>) and New Lantau Bus (NLB) (<https://www.nlb.com.hk/>). Route and fare information can be found on their company websites. Alternatively it is also wise to install transportation apps such as "App 1933" and "CitybusNWFB" into your smartphone to check fares outdoors if you use mobile devices regularly during your stay.

The resort towns of Discovery Bay and Ma Wan have separate bus services provided by their real-estate developers, namely Discovery Bay Transportation Services (<https://www.visitdiscoverybay.com/en/getting-around>) and Park Island Transport (http://www.pitcl.com.hk/en/bus_service.php).

Fares depend more on where you board rather than where you get-off (except for the cross-boundary route B2 and a few overnight buses) which means it is more



Geographically accurate map of the Light Rail network



A Kowloon Motor Bus double-decker bus.

Tip on bus routes

Alphabets in bus routes represent the nature of the route. As a rule of thumb:

- Bus routes starting with **A** terminate at or stop at the airport.
- Bus routes starting with **B** terminate at the land border crossings.
- Bus routes starting with **E** connect Lantau Island and the city centre. They *may or may not stop* at the airport.
- Bus routes starting with **N** are night routes.
- Bus routes starting with **K** are MTR feeder routes which

expensive to board at an earlier stop on a route rather than the later ones. Hence, the price of bus rides crossing the harbour between Kowloon and the Island exceeds \$9 prior to the crossing. The fare is displayed on a digital display above the farebox - one may pay in cash (but no change is given), Octopus Card, contactless VISA or Mastercard (on some routes; including those embedded on Apple Pay and Google Pay), or a ticket purchased from a bus travel centre (only applicable to a few routes found at major transit hubs such as Star Ferry or Central Bus Terminus) must be used. There are plenty of bus routes that provide a fare discount for transferring with a particular set of routes; they are often confusing for visitors, however instructions are written on bus stop timetable leaflets. There are also some bus routes (especially the routes going to Stanley) which offer a discount if a passenger gets off early and taps the Octopus card again prior to alighting.

There are announcements in Cantonese, Mandarin and English except for most buses on New Lantau Bus. To catch your bus, go to the bus stop with the right number and when your bus approaches, raise your arm to hail the bus (like you would hail a taxi). Buses only stop when requested so press the red buzzer (by the exit doors and on the grab-rails) to signal to the driver that you want to alight. Passengers should always board at the front and alight from the centre door.

The MTR also maintains a fleet of feeder buses. MTR passengers can enjoy a free feeder service if the bus trip is paid for on an Octopus card along with a connecting railway journey (except for taking K12 on holidays).

By public light buses/minibuses

Van-sized **public light buses** or **minibuses** serve both feeder and trunk routes, carry a maximum of 19 passengers (seats only) and come in two varieties, **red minibuses** and **green minibuses** (the red buses are also called **maxicabs**); the colour refers to a wide stripe painted on top of the vehicle.

- Most minibus station signs only offer Chinese description, and may have nothing more than the route number on the sign. Location markers of minibus stations on online maps are also spotty. Translation apps like Google Translate (including its camera function) and asking other passengers are useful ways to determine whether the route serves your destination.

terminate at MTR stations.

- Bus routes starting with **W** terminate at West Kowloon Station. Other bus routes also serve the station and neighbouring Kowloon Station, but may take a longer time to reach your destination.
- Bus routes ending with **M** terminate at MTR stations.
- Bus routes ending with **K** terminate at **East** line or **Tuen Ma** line stations.
- Bus routes ending with **P** are commuter routes which only operate within rush hours.
- Bus routes ending with **R** are holiday and public activity routes, which only operate on holidays or immediately after the activity has ended.
- Bus routes ending with **X** are express routes.
- 3-digit bus routes starting with **1, 6, or 9** are cross-harbour routes that pass through the Cross-Harbour Tunnel, Eastern Harbour Crossing and Western Harbour Crossing respectively.
- 3-digit bus routes starting with **3** are commuter cross-harbour routes which only operate within rush hours.
- 3-digit bus routes starting with **8** are horse-racing routes that depart from Sha Tin Racecourse. They only operate on horse-racing days and do not transport passengers to the racecourse.



A typical green public light bus



- Riding a minibus may not be easy for travellers, as it is required to call out the name of the stop and/or ask the driver to stop in Cantonese (shouting *please stop* loudly in English usually suffices), but more light buses are equipped with bells to notify the driver. Some station names used by minibuses may be outdated.
- If a minibus station requires diversion from a green minibus' usual route and nobody on the minibus asked to stop, drivers may ignore the stop and take short cuts. The foolproof way for travellers is to inform the driver of your destination and remind the driver again when the minibus is approaching your destination.
- Minibuses sometimes depart from terminus only if they're full, so consider include waiting time if you're boarding a minibus at its terminus.
- Some red minibuses still do not accept Octopus but will give you change, while green minibuses accept Octopus payment but cannot give you change if you pay in cash. Prices on red minibuses are often displayed only in Chinese numbers. The price displayed on a red minibus can vary according to the market price, so one might need to pay more at busy times and on special occasions (such as during a typhoon or demonstration), though it is rare.
- Minibus drivers generally drive fast, especially at night. All minibuses have a large digital speedometer in the cabin to discourage speeding and accidents. Dial ☎ [+852-2754-7668](tel:+852-2754-7668) to report dangerous driving if you encounter them.
 - Always use minibus seatbelts where available, as it's against the law not to use them. Seatbelts are often ignored by minibus passengers, but the police occasionally have an annual or bi-annual crackdown where offenders may be fined. Faulty seatbelts may also be encountered even on new minibuses: show it to the police officers, and they would likely to spare you from tickets.
- The Hong Kong Island green minibus #1 down from the Peak to Central is particularly exhilarating. Red minibuses tend to have a more Chinese feel than green buses.

There are six independent route numbering systems, applying to: buses (i) on Hong Kong Island, (ii) in Kowloon and the New Territories, and (iii) on Lantau Island; green minibuses (iv) on Hong Kong Island, (v) in Kowloon, and (vi) in New Territories and several exceptional auxiliary bus routes. Red minibuses do not usually have a route number. This leads to duplication of routes in different regions.

Generally you need not mention which district the route belongs to when you are asking for directions (almost all people will assume you are asking for the route which runs in the district you are in), but you really need to mention whether the route is by bus or minibus when you ask, since in some cases both buses and minibuses can have the same route number in the same area which are different routes.

By ferry

A large fleet of ferries sail between the many islands of Hong Kong. The granddaddy of them all and an attraction in itself is the **Star Ferry (<http://www.starferry.com.hk>)**, whose most popular line travels between Tsim Sha Tsui and Central from early morning until late at night, and offers amazing views (especially when coming from Tsim Sha Tsui). The Star Ferry is an icon of Hong Kong heritage and has carried passengers for over 120 years. Taking its 11-minute ride across the harbour and catching some misty breeze is considered a "must do" when visiting Hong Kong. Navigation enthusiasts will also not want to miss the sight of the crew using a billhook to catch the thrown rope as it moors at the pier, a practice unchanged since the first ferry ran in 1888.

Upper deck seats cost \$2.50 on weekdays and \$3.40 on weekends while the lower deck costs \$2.00 on weekdays and \$2.80 on weekends, both payable with Octopus, cash (no change given) or by onsite vending machine. The Star Ferry also operates between Tsim Sha Tsui and Wanchai but only offers upper-deck seating. A 4-day tourist ticket is also available for \$25.

Ferries to Lamma, Lantau and other islands depart from a variety of ports, but the largest and most important terminal is at Central adjacent to the Star Ferry. Ferries are usually divided into **fast ferries** and **slow ferries**, with fast ferries charging around twice the price for half the journey time, although not all destinations offer both kinds of service. Example fares for trips from Central to Yung Shue Wan (Lamma) are \$10/15 slow/fast, and to Mui Wo (Lantau) \$10.50/\$21. All fares increase by around 50% on Sundays and public holidays. There is sometimes an extra charge for seating in an air-conditioned area.

Ferry services known as **kai-to** (街渡 / 街舫) serve the city's most remote islands, in which some are also tourist attractions. These ferries are often operated by small motorised sampans. A list of these services can be found on the website of the Transport Department (https://www.td.gov.hk/en/transport_in_hong_kong/public_transport/ferries/kaito_services_map/service_details/index.html), and are listed on Apple Maps as proper ferries.

By taxi

Taxis are plentiful, and are relatively cheap compared to those in Western cities. Unfortunately, Hong Kong taxi drivers are known to be unprofessional and shamelessly rude, and sometimes overcharge passengers. Reckless speeding should be expected in most rides.

In general, there are three types of taxi in Hong Kong, easily identified by their colours: red, green and blue, all of which serve the airport and Hong Kong Disneyland. Taxis that have different colours are fleet taxis, which operate like ridesharing companies but will also carry passengers who flag them down on the street. When in doubt, just take a red taxi.

Rates for each type of taxi are published online (https://www.td.gov.hk/en/transport_in_hong_kong/public_transport/taxi/taxi_fare_of_hong_kong/). Taxi fleets can set their own rates (usually more expensive) when booked, but must follow these rates when flagged down. Rates as of July 2024:



Star Ferry at Tsim Sha Tsui ferry pier with the Island skyline in the background. 



Crew using billhook to catch mooring rope. 



A kai-to operating between Aberdeen and Ap Lei Chau 



Red taxis in Kowloon



Name of taxi	Taxi colour	Service area	Flag down (for first 2 km)	Rate for extra 200 m or 2 minutes of waiting	
				higher rate	lower rate
Urban	Red	Anywhere except Southern Lantau Island	\$29	\$2.10 (up to \$102.50)	\$1.40 (after \$102.50)
New Territories	Green		\$25.50	\$1.90 (up to \$82.50)	\$1.40 (after \$82.50)
Lantau	Blue	Lantau Island, Hong Kong International Airport and the Hong Kong-Zhuhai-Macao Bridge Hong Kong Port.	\$24	\$1.90 (up to \$195)	\$1.60 (after \$195)

Considerations when riding taxis:

- Wearing of seat belts is obligatory; a taxi will not carry extra passengers.
- Tipping is usually not required or expected, however the driver will sometimes round the fare up to the nearest dollar.
- Drivers are required to provide change for \$100 notes, but not for higher denominations. If you only have a \$500 or \$1000 note and are going through a tunnel, let the driver know beforehand and he will change it when paying at the toll booth.
- Some taxis accept credit cards, Octopus cards or mobile payment to avoid hassles with small change; these are usually indicated by a sticker in the windscreen. Fleet taxis should accept these payment methods.
- There are no extra late-night charges nor peak-hour surcharges. No charges are levied for airport travel or travel within the centre, but all toll charges for tunnels are added to the bill. The driver will normally pay on your behalf at the toll booth and you just need to reimburse him before alighting.
- Baggage carried in the boot will cost you \$5 per piece even if you lift it yourself, except for wheelchairs.
- Harbour crossing passengers (Hong Kong Island to Kowloon or vice versa) are expected to pay the return tolls (e.g. if the tunnel toll is \$5, then you will need to pay for \$10 on top of your taxi charge). But you can use this to your advantage by picking a homebound taxi from a cross-harbour taxi rank in places like the Star Ferry pier or Hung Hom station. In cross-harbour taxi stands, only single toll charge will be applied to the taxi fare.
- Taxi drivers must display an official name card that includes the driver's photograph and the license plate number. Unless a taxi has an out of service sign displayed, they are legally required to take you to your destination. They must provide a receipt upon request.
- All taxis are radio equipped and can be reserved and requested via an operator for \$5, payable to the driver. You are unlikely to need to call a taxi, though, as they are plentiful.
- Take your hotel's business card to show the driver the address in Chinese, as drivers speak limited English or Mandarin. Get your hotel concierge to write the name or address of your

destination in Chinese. When using a maps app on a phone, your destination may also have a Chinese name which you can show to the driver.

- Learning some Cantonese pronunciation for your location will help (especially as some names don't sound in Cantonese like they are written in English). "Do" (said like "Doe" – a deer, a female deer, with a middle tone) and "Gai" (said more like "Kai" with a rising tone) are the Cantonese words for Road and Street respectively. If you can pronounce your suburb and local road correctly, this will help considerably.
- Mobile taxi apps like eTaxi (<https://etaxi.com.hk/en/index.html>) and **HKTaxi** are becoming widespread in Hong Kong. You always get a fair price, all payments are done by card, there's no need to call anyone, and you can get a taxi at any time in less than 10 minutes.
- Uber (<https://www.uber.com>) continues to operate in Hong Kong despite a multi-year legal battle with the government. While the government is planning to legalize ridesharing, the industry is illegal as of July 2025. Drivers without the appropriate permits run the risk of fines, but passengers don't. Uber also operates Uber Taxi (<https://www.uber.com/hk/zh-hk/ride/uber-taxi/>), which is free from legal ambiguity.

You may file a complaint to the Transport Complaints Unit Complaint Hotline at ☎ +852-2889-9999 or via [their online complaint form \(https://www.tcu.gov.hk/eng/taxi-complaint.html\)](https://www.tcu.gov.hk/eng/taxi-complaint.html). When filing a complaint, do note the taxi driver's name and licence plate for identification.

By car

Main article: [Driving in Hong Kong](#)

Traffic in Hong Kong moves on the left (the steering wheel is on the right-hand side), opposite to mainland China. Hong Kong is densely populated, has heavy traffic, a complex road network, and rare and expensive parking spaces, making driving very unappealing for most visitors. Furthermore, it is well-connected by public transportation, so a car may not be necessary. However, there are parts of the New Territories, Lantau Island and southern Hong Kong Island that are poorly served by public transport. The main article has information on driving, renting a car, and crossing the border from mainland China with a car.

By bicycle

Hong Kong is generally not a bicycle-friendly place because of its hilly landscapes, government policies, air pollution and a general lack of consideration by many motorists. Locals sometimes cycle on the pavements if they are not crowded, although most of the time, pavements are too crowded even for pushing your bike. If you plan to use busy urban roads you should be fit enough to keep up with the traffic, which moves surprisingly quickly.

A network of paved cycling trails sprawls across the New Territories making it relatively easy to bike for longer distances, with the longest one stretching 60km from Tuen Mun to Ma On Shan. Unlike cycling in Kowloon and northern Hong Kong Island, riding on these tracks is quite enjoyable for the scenic rural views along the way. Southern Lantau Island is also a good place to cycle, as motor vehicle traffic is heavily restricted and consequently light on the roads there. Visitors should comply with the [Road User's Code \(https://www.td.gov.hk/filemanager/en/content_172/road_users_code_2020_eng.pdf\)](https://www.td.gov.hk/filemanager/en/content_172/road_users_code_2020_eng.pdf). Visit this page (https://www.td.gov.hk/mini_site/cic/en/cycling-infrastructure/cycle-tracks-and-parkings/index.html) for maps of major cycle tracks.

There are also several mountain bike trails in the country parks, although a permit is necessary to bring your bicycle into the parks.

Bike rental is available in several locations across the territory. Popular rental spots include Cheung Chau, Mui Wo (Lantau), Sha Tin, Tai Po Market, Tuen Mun and Ma On Shan. Rental fees are typically \$40–60 a day for a standard entry-level mountain bike, or around \$150 per day for a higher-spec mountain or road bike.

Basic rules to follow:

- Cyclists are prohibited from riding on expressways and in tunnels, which are well patrolled.
- It is an offence to be drunk while cycling.
- By law, you're required to have a front white and rear red light when cycling at night or in poor visibility.
- Electronic bike conversion systems are not allowed. The police have a strict enforcement policy on this offence.
- The maximum penalty for riding on pedestrian walkways is \$500 or a three-month jail sentence. Usually offenders get a warning, but the police occasionally have an annual, or bi-annual crackdown.
- For folding bike users, sometimes a bus driver will tell you that it's not allowed, but if you talk to them nicely they will usually let you board. A bicycle bag that makes your bike look like ordinary luggage can make your life a lot easier.

Bicycles on public transport

Folding bicycles are permitted on all public transport, provided that they are folded.

- **MTR:** Non-folding bicycles are permitted to travel on the MTR system. Travel in the first or last carriage and remove the front wheel.
- **Ferries:** Bicycles are permitted on board slow ferries including the Star Ferry, but are not permitted on the Fast Ferries.
- **Taxis:** Most taxi drivers will carry bikes in the boot if the front wheel is removed. Some drivers will carry your bike for free, others will legitimately charge extra for 'excess baggage'.

By escalator

The **world's longest outdoor escalator system** travels from Central through Soho to the residential developments of the Mid-levels. The escalator moves down in the morning rush hour but up the rest of the time, and using it is free — in fact, you can even get Octopus credits from machines along the way for being willing to use your feet! The escalator is covered, but still relatively exposed to the elements.

The escalator cuts through some of the oldest streets found anywhere in Hong Kong, so if you are happy to take a chance and just wander and explore the back streets you are likely to find something of interest that dates back to colonial times.

See

Hong Kong doesn't have street benches to sit down. Whilst "sitting out areas" are around, these are generally infrequent. Additionally, restaurants (especially cheap and quick ones) will prefer quick table turnover. All this adds up to spending a considerable amount of time on your feet in any given day. Make sure you have a pair of comfortable shoes, as even a good pair of shoes will still leave your feet sore after a full day on your feet.

Itineraries

- Hong Kong Culinary Tour — gives a short tour to discover the unique cuisine of Hong Kong
- Hong Kong to Kunming overland — covers one route to or from Hong Kong

Guided walks

A list of guided tours is available on the website of the Hong Kong Tourism Board (<https://www.discoverhongkong.com/us/plan/guided-tour.html>).

Victoria Peak

Get a stunning view of Hong Kong Island on Victoria Peak atop the giant, wok-shaped Peak Tower! Ever since the dawn of British colonisation, the Peak hosted the most exclusive neighbourhood for the territory's richest residents. Prior to World War II, non-white people weren't permitted to even set foot here (except for domestic servants of the resident white families). The Peak Tower has an observation platform and a shopping mall with shops, fine dining, and museums. Read more at Hong Kong/Central#Victoria Peak.

Horse racing

Horse racing was introduced by the British during the colonial period, and remains serious business in Hong Kong. There are live broadcasts over the radio and many people bet regularly. When people are listening to the races, expect no conversation or business to transpire for the 1-2 minute duration of the race.

With the exception of a summer break between mid-July and mid-September, horse races take place on Wednesdays and on weekends, at either **Sha Tin Racecourse** in the New Territories or **Happy Valley Racecourse** on Eastern Hong Kong Island. Both locations are easily accessible by MTR. Happy Valley is the more convenient, historic, and impressive location, though Sha Tin is larger and hosts more top-level international races.

Get a local to explain the betting system to you. Read Racing Post by the South China Morning Post (<http://racing.scmp.com/>) on race days for a guide to the race. A beer garden (<http://entertainment.hkjc.com/entertainment/english/go-racing/happy-valley-racecourse/beer-garden.aspx>) is at the finish line of Happy Valley. Bring your passport and get in at the tourist rate of just \$1 (compared to \$10 for locals).

Betting can also be placed at any of the more than 100 branches of the Hong Kong Jockey Club. Expect long lines and big crowds.

Traditional heritage

There are many traditional heritage locations throughout Hong Kong.

In Kowloon you will find the **Kowloon Walled City Park** at the location of the former Kowloon Walled City, which has the remnants of the city's south gate, and a small open-air museum. In New Territories you will find **Ping Shan Heritage Trail** passing by some of the most important ancient sights, the walled Hakka village of **Tsang Tai Uk**, **Fu Shin Street**

Traditional Bazaar as well as temples including **Man Mo Temple** and the **Temple of Ten Thousand Buddhas**. And on Lantau you will find the **Stilt houses in Tai O**, **Po Lin Monastery** and the **Tian Tan Buddha Statue**.

Hong Kong has traditionally been known for **Cantonese opera** (粵劇), which as the name suggests, originates in Guangdong province. This art form employs colourful props and costumes, with stories usually set in ancient China, and is a display of singing, martial arts, acting and acrobatics.

Museums

There are a variety of museums in Hong Kong with different themes. Arguably the best museum is the **Hong Kong Museum of History** in Kowloon, which gives an excellent overview of Hong Kong's fascinating past. Only an abridged version of the museum's permanent exhibit is available while the museum is being renovated.

Kowloon also has a number of other interesting museums including **Dialogue in the Dark**, which is an exhibition in complete darkness where you should use your non-visual senses with the help of a visually impaired guide, Hong Kong **Museum of Art**, which is a fascinating, strange and elusive place exhibiting Chinese ceramics, terracotta, rhinoceros horn and Chinese paintings as well as contemporary art produced by Hong Kong artists, Hong Kong **Science Museum**, primarily aimed at children, and Hong Kong **Heritage Discovery Centre**.

Central also has its share of museums including **Dr Sun Yat-sen Museum**, Hong Kong **Maritime Museum**, Hong Kong **Museum of Medical Sciences**, which shows how the healthcare system evolved from traditional Chinese medicine to modern Western medicine, and Hong Kong **Visual Arts Centre**. There is also a 3D museum from Korea called **Trick Eye Museum Hong Kong**.

The Hong Kong **Palace Museum** in West Kowloon is a branch of the Palace Museum in Beijing's Forbidden City, and largely dedicated to displaying artifacts from the Forbidden City's collection.

Nature

Contrary to popular belief, Hong Kong is not all skyscrapers and it is worthwhile to go to the countryside (over 70% of Hong Kong), including the country parks (https://www.afcd.gov.hk/english/country/cou_vis/cou_vis_cou/cou_vis_cou.html) and marine parks (<https://www.afcd.go>



Stilt Houses in Tai O



Murray House



Tian Tan Buddha



v.hk/english/country/cou_vis/cou_vis_mar/cou_vis_mar.html). Many are surprised to find that Hong Kong is actually home to some stunning landscapes and breathtaking scenery.

- Lantau Island is twice as big as Hong Kong island and is well worth checking out if you want to get away from the bright lights and pollution of the city for a spell. Here you will find open countryside, traditional fishing villages, secluded beaches, monasteries and more. You can hike, camp, fish and mountain bike, among other activities.
- In the waters just off Tung Chung on Lantau Island, live the Chinese White Dolphin. These dolphins are naturally pink and live in the wild, but their status is threatened, with the population estimated to be between 100 and 200.
- The **Sai Kung Peninsula** in New Territories is also a worthwhile place to visit. Its mountainous terrain and spectacular coastal scenery make this a special place. There are both challenging and more relaxed routes.
- **Hong Kong Wetland Park** in New Territories is a relaxing park set amidst an ecological mitigation area. One can stroll along a network of boardwalks or explore the large visitors centre/museum.
- North East New Territories is also famous for its natural environment. **Yan Chau Tong Marine Park** is in the North East New Territories. A few traditional abandoned villages are connected by hiking trails in the territory. North East New Territories is a famous hiking hot spot for the locals.
- Short hiking trails (2 hours) can be found on Hong Kong Island and the New Territories. You can even hike up to the Victoria Peak.
- Some outlying islands are worth visiting, e.g., Lamma Island, Cheung Chau, Ping Chau, Tap Mun, and Tung Lung Island.



Tai Mei Tuk country park, looking south towards Shatin town, north eastern Hong Kong.

Theme parks

- **Hong Kong Disneyland Resort** on Lantau Island features a Disneyland park, three resort hotels and a lake recreation centre. It offers some great attractions and short queues most of the year.
- **Ocean Park** is on the southern side of Hong Kong island, and is the park that grew up with many local Hong Kong people. With roller coasters and large aquariums altogether, it is still packed on weekends with families and tourists. The cablecar is an icon. For many, the chance to see Hong Kong's pandas would be a deciding factor.
- **Ngong Ping 360** on Lantau Island is a Buddhist-themed park that features Imperial Chinese architecture, interactive shows, demonstrations, restaurants and coffee shops. The highlight of this trip is the longest cable car ride in Hong Kong that affords stunning views. The ride also takes you to the largest outdoor seated Buddha.



Fireworks at Hong Kong Disneyland Resort

Seeing Hong Kong by public transport

Travelling on a bus or a tram is ideal for looking at different sides of Hong Kong. Not only is it cheap, it allows you to see completely different lifestyles in different districts in a short time. See [Touring Hong Kong by public transport](#) for details.



Ngong Ping 360



Avenue of Stars and A Symphony of Lights

Hong Kong's version of the Hollywood Walk of Fame and Grauman's Chinese Theatre combined into one, the **Avenue of Stars** celebrates icons of Hong Kong cinema from the 20th century. The seaside promenade in [Kowloon](#) offers fantastic views, day and night, of Victoria Harbour and the skyline. This is also a great place to see A Symphony of Lights, a light and laser show synchronised to music and staged every night at 8PM.

Do

Pop culture

Hong Kong was one of the main centres of Chinese pop culture from the communist revolution in 1949 until the 2010s, having given rise to many famous singers and actors. Hong Kong action cinema is legendary among Chinese people around the world. The city also played a key role in popularizing the genre of Cantopop, and some Cantopop songs have achieved cult status across the Chinese-speaking world, even among people who do not speak Cantonese. Television dramas by local station TVB also enjoyed loyal following among ethnic Chinese around the world.

Since the 2010s, most of Hong Kong's top singers and actors have relocated to mainland China where they can make a lot more money. Nevertheless, the city continues to produce notable films on a regular basis, and Cantopop has experienced a revival of sorts in the 2020s, led by a new generation of local talent.

Music festivals

Clockenflap (<https://www.clockenflap.com/>) is Hong Kong's largest music festival, and includes popular artists, mainly from Europe and the US. It takes place in November on the Central Harbourfront Event Space.

Indie events

Cantopop is by far the most popular genre in Hong Kong and receives an immense amount of support from the media. Independent musicians are often harassed and evicted from their rehearsal rooms and concert venues by the government because they are forced to illegally rent warehouse spaces due to unaffordable rents. A few small venues are open for indie shows, such as Hidden Agenda and The Wanch.

Comedy

Hong Kong is home to one of Asia's most vibrant stand-up comedy scenes, with the scene being anchored by **Take Out Comedy Club** (<https://www.takeoutcomedy.net/>), the first full-time comedy club in Asia, and **Backstage Comedy** (<https://linktr.ee/backstagecomedy>). Some pubs also have open mic nights for aspiring stand-up comedy performers; see **COMEDY.HK** (<https://comedy.hk/>) for the complete listing of live comedy shows in Hong Kong. Both Cantonese and English shows are performed regularly, so you should not have much difficulty finding an English show as a tourist.

Beaches

You are never far from the sea in Hong Kong and going to a good beach is only a bus-ride away. However, if you want a really good beach, then it is worth making the effort to travel, possibly on foot, and seek out the beaches of the New Territories. With more than 200 outlying islands, as well as an extensive coastline that is jam-packed with impressive bays and beaches, you will surely come across some good looking beaches to while the whole day away. Hong Kong's urban beaches are usually well maintained and have services such as showers and changing rooms. Where beaches are managed by the Leisure and Cultural Services Department, shark nets and life guards are present. Dogs and smoking are not permitted on these beaches.

The best beaches to use include:

Repulse Bay is a large urban beach on the south side of Hong Kong island that features a colourful Chinese temple. Money has been spent on its facilities and will appeal to those who have young children.

Middle Bay is popular with gay people and is a 20-minute walk from the crowds at Repulse Bay. Middle Bay has lifeguards, showers, changing rooms, shark nets and a decent cafe serving drinks and snacks.

Shek O is a beach popular with many young locals. It is away from the bustle of the city but is well served by restaurants and has a good bus service from the north side of the island. The Thai restaurant close to the beach is worth a try.

Big Wave Bay is smaller than other beaches on Hong Kong Island, but has good services which include a number of small cafes close to the beach. Big Wave Bay has the sort of waves that appeal to surfers. From here it is possible to take the coastal footpath to Chai Wan where you can find the MTR and buses. The walk to Chai Wan is about one hour, or more if you are not used to the steep climb up the mountain.

Hung Shing Yeh Beach on Lamma Island is the most popular beach. This beach is Grade 1 and shows off powdery, fine sand and clear water. This beach has changing facilities, a barbecue area, and a refreshment kiosk. Take the ferryboat from Central Pier to Yung Shue Wan; expect to walk around 20 minutes from the ferry terminal to the beach (buses and taxis are not an option on Lamma).

Swimming pools

In addition to pools in many hotels, there are several public swimming pools (<https://www.lcsd.gov.hk/en/beach/swim-intro.html>) scattered across the territory. Entrance costs \$19 on weekends/\$17 on weekdays for adults and \$9 on weekends/\$8 on weekdays for children, usually only payable by Octopus Card or by coins. Swimming pools are child-friendly with shallow pools and fountains. All swimming pool complexes are well maintained and offer swimming lanes, hot showers, lockers (\$5 coin deposit or your own lock required), both family and same-sex changing rooms (limited privacy), and most have swimming clubs for serious swimmers. Swimmers are expected to provide their own towels and toiletries. The Kowloon Park Swimming Pool Complex in Tsim Sha Tsui is centrally located and offers visitors a wide range of services and includes an indoor Olympic-sized pool.

Most pools open at 6:30AM and close at 10PM. They generally close for lunch noon-1PM and then again from 5-6PM.

Sailing

You can rent a **Junk Boat** for a sailing trip. A typical junk boat can accommodate more than 30 people and can be rented for the day to take you on a tour of your choice. Sai Kung is a popular spot for the trip to start and you can sail to nearby beaches for a more secluded time. A cheaper alternative is to hire a much smaller water taxi (水道) to take you to where you want to go.

There are a few boats that operate "sunset cruises" on the harbour.

Sports

The sports landscape in Hong Kong generally reflects its legacy of British colonial rule. Hong Kong sends its own team to international sports competitions, separate from the Chinese team. Hong Kong also sends a team to China's National Games. It will host the fencing, track cycling, golf, rugby sevens, beach volleyball, triathlon, tenpin bowling, men's handball and men's U22 basketball events for the 2025 National Games, to be held on 9-21 November.

The most popular sport in Hong Kong is **football (soccer)**, and while the local league and national team are not of a high standard, it has the highest participation rate among all team sports in Hong Kong. The main home stadium of the Hong Kong national team is the Hong Kong Stadium in Causeway Bay, but some home games may be played at the Mong Kok Stadium instead.

Rugby union is also popular, with the territory hosting the **Hong Kong Sevens** (<https://hksevens.com/>), the world's most prestigious rugby sevens tournament, every year at Hong Kong Stadium. Hong Kong also has a respectable rugby union national team, which is the second strongest in Asia after Japan.

Cricket is most popular among the South Asian and Eurasian (European and Asian mixed-race) communities, and membership in the Hong Kong Cricket Club or Kowloon Cricket Club is somewhat of a status symbol for Hongkongers. Due to Hong Kong's mild climate, cricket is generally played in the winter months (Sept-April). Hong Kong is a third-tier ICC team,

occasionally entering qualifying rounds for major tournaments but not routinely facing the stronger nations. The Hong Kong national cricket team plays at Tin Kwong Road (formerly Mission Road) in Kowloon.

The **Kau Sai Chau Public Golf Course** (<https://www.kscgolf.org.hk/>), on the eponymous island, is Hong Kong's only public golf course.

Hiking and camping

Hiking is the best kept secret in Hong Kong, it is a great way to appreciate Hong Kong's beautiful landscapes that include mountains, beaches and breathtaking cityscapes. The starting points for many hiking trails are accessible by bus, minibus or taxi.



Pui O beach is a great destination for campers  at Sai Kung East Country Park

Hiking in Hong Kong can be strenuous because of the steep trails, and during the summer months, mosquitos and the hot, humid, weather combine to make even the easiest trek a workout. Wear suitable clothes, and bring plenty of water and mosquito repellent. It is fairly unlikely that you will have a close encounter with venomous snakes, although they are present in most rural areas. Most local people choose the winter months to undertake the more demanding hiking trails. If you are not especially fit you might plan your route so that you take a bus or taxi to the highest point of the trail and then walk downhill.

Campsites in Hong Kong are plentiful and free of charge. Most are in country parks and range from basic sites serviced with only with a pit toilet, to those that provide campers with modern toilet blocks and cold showers. Some sites have running water and sinks for washing dishes. A few campsites have places to buy drinking water and food. Whilst many are serenely remote, weekends and public holidays are predictably busy, especially in the more accessible places close to roads. Hongkongers who camp like to do so in large groups, talk loudly, and stay awake late into the night. If you are noise sensitive try to find a remote campsite or pack some good earplugs.

There are four major trails in Hong Kong, consisting of different sections with varying difficulty.

- Lantau Trail on Lantau.
- Hong Kong Trail on Hong Kong Island.
- Maclehose Trail through the New Territories.
- Wilson Trail starting on Hong Kong Island and finishing in the New Territories.

There are also shorter country trails which are *generally* easier than the average major trails. For first-time hikers, family walks offers newbie-friendly terrain that can be finished within hours.

Hong Kong has some exceptional rural landscapes but visitor impact is an issue. Respect the countryside by taking your litter home with you. Avoid putting food in litter bins in remote areas as these are not emptied on a regular basis and your trash may be strewn around by hungry animals.

Hong Kong Outdoors (<https://www.hkoutdoors.com>) is packed with information on hiking and camping, and other great things to do and places to go in the wilderness areas of Hong Kong.

Gambling

While the closest casinos are in Macau, other forms of gambling are legal and regulated in Hong Kong. The minimum age for gambling is 18, and Hong Kong Jockey Club branches will refuse service to those who are wearing student uniform.

- **Horse racing** is the most popular and is further detailed above.
- **Football** betting is legal only at branches of the Hong Kong Jockey Club (<https://www.hkjc.com/home/english/>). Betting on other sports is prohibited.
- **Lottery** is also legal only at branches of the Hong Kong Jockey Club (<https://www.hkjc.com/home/english/>). Marksix (<https://bet.hkjc.com/marksix/?lang=en>) is a popular game costing \$10 per bet. You pick 6 of 49 numbers, and the lottery result will be announced on Tuesdays, Thursdays, and weekends that don't have horse racing scheduled.
- **Mahjong** (麻雀 *màh jéuk*) also forms an integral part of Hong Kong gambling culture, although it is often informal and difficult for foreigners to get involved with. Mahjong has a strong influence on Hong Kong pop culture, with a history of songs, films and television series based on a mahjong theme. The game played in Hong Kong is the Cantonese version, which differs in rules and scoring from the Japanese version, Taiwanese version or the versions played in other parts of China. Mahjong parlours are plentiful, although hard to find. They also have many unwritten rules that visitors may find hard to understand.

Spas

Hong Kong's luxury hotels like the Peninsula, Ritz-Carlton, Mandarin Oriental and Four Seasons have day spas where the well-heeled traveller can shell out top dollar for a few hours of pampering. However, traditional East Asian-style bathhouses like the ones in Japan, South Korea and Taiwan cannot be found in Hong Kong. For more budget friendly and comprehensive experiences, do as many locals do and head across the border to Shenzhen. Many spas in Shenzhen provide shuttles from the border crossings to cater to customers coming from Hong Kong.

Learn

Universities

Hong Kong has 12 universities. The oldest, the **University of Hong Kong** (<https://www.hku.hk>) (香港大學, abbreviated HKU in English or 港大 in Chinese), is considered to be one of Asia's top universities. Other highly rated universities in Hong Kong include the **Chinese University of Hong Kong** (<https://www.cuhk.edu.hk/english/index.html>) (香港中文大學, abbreviated CUHK in English or 中大 in Chinese) and **Hong Kong University of Science and Technology** (<https://www.ust.hk>) (香港科技大學). Most universities have exchange agreements with foreign universities, offering a good opportunity to study in Hong Kong. Courses for exchange students are often conducted in English.

Learning Cantonese

Some universities and private institutions offer Cantonese lessons for foreigners. This is a good way for those living in Hong Kong for an extended period of time to learn the local language. Like Taiwan and Macau, but unlike mainland China, the script taught is traditional Chinese.



Main building of the University of Hong Kong



Work

Unless you are already a citizen or permanent resident of Hong Kong then you will need an **employment visa** in order to work. This usually involves potential employers making an application to the Immigration Department on your behalf; crucially you should have skills or qualifications that are in short supply in the local job market. Illegal working is punishable by **3 years of imprisonment** plus deportation. Hong Kong courts are very tough on sentencing illegal workers, and one should not expect leniency if caught.

Spouses of employment visa holders can apply for a **dependent visa** which has no limitations for working within Hong Kong (except jobs requiring permanent residency status), although it will terminate at the same time as the visa of the main holder. Spouses who are citizens of the PRC may face issues in obtaining a dependent visa unless they have been living outside the PRC for more than a year.

The Quality Migrant Application Scheme targets highly skilled workers (*preferably university educated*) to come and settle in Hong Kong and seek employment. For more information, visit the website of the Hong Kong Immigration Department (<https://www.immd.gov.hk>). Hong Kong has a small ESL market; teachers will typically need a bachelor's degree and a TESOL certification. ESL teachers in Hong Kong can expect to earn \$12,000-25,000 (monthly) and will usually teach 30 to 40 hours a week. Contracts will sometimes include accommodation and airfare.

You are eligible to apply for **permanent residency** after living in Hong Kong on a temporary permit for 7 years or more continuously, which allows you to live and work in Hong Kong indefinitely with no restrictions. You must be physically residing in Hong Kong during this time without any long absences. Permanent residency can also be obtained by investing a lot of money in a local business. Check with the immigration department for more details.

Young people between 18 and 30 years old who are citizens of Australia, Austria, Canada, France, Germany, Ireland, Japan, New Zealand, South Korea and United Kingdom are eligible to apply for a **working holiday visa** (valid for 6 months for Austrian citizens, 12 months for others), allowing them to take up temporary work and a short period of study in Hong Kong. Visit the Immigration Department's website (https://www.immd.gov.hk/eng/services/visas/working_holiday_scheme.html) for more information.

Hong Kong's personal and corporate income tax rates are among the lowest in the world, making it a popular tax haven for many of the world's richest people, and a popular place for multinational corporations to set up their Asia-Pacific headquarters.

Buy

Credit/debit cards are widely accepted in Hong Kong, but street vendors and most taxis still expect cash, so it's wise to have some on hand. Octopus payments are also common for smaller purchases like transport, convenience stores and chain restaurants. Mobile/QR code payments are gaining traction but remain far less common than in mainland China.

Money

The **Hong Kong dollar**, denoted by the symbol "\$" (港元 or 港幣, ISO code **HKD**), is the territory's currency. In Cantonese, one dollar is known formally as the 圓 (*yùn*) and colloquially as the 蚊 (*mān*). It is subdivided into 100 cents (symbol ¢). In Cantonese, one cent is known as a 仙 (*sīn*), and ten cents is known as a 毫 (*hòu*). You can assume that the '\$' sign used in this travel guide and in the territory refers to HKD. The HKD is also widely accepted in Macau in lieu of its own currency at a 1:1 rate.

The official exchange rate is fixed in a range of HK\$7.75-7.85 to US\$1, although bank rates may fluctuate slightly. When exchanging currency at a big bank, be prepared to pay a small fixed commission, usually about \$40 per transaction. If exchanging large amounts, this commission will have a negligible impact on the transaction. If exchanging small amounts, it may be advantageous to exchange at one of many independent exchange stalls or pawnshops found in tourist areas. Although their exchange rates compared with big banks may be slightly less favourable, most do not charge a commission. They may also be more convenient and a faster way to exchange (no queues, in shopping centres, open 24 hours, minimal paperwork, etc.) However, be wary of using independent exchangers outside banking hours because, without competition from big banks, their rates may be very uncompetitive.

If you go to the right place, Hong Kong can be an excellent place to **exchange money**, including from one foreign currency to another (i.e. non-HK\$ pairs), as some places offer very good exchange rates with low or no commissions, and without the various restrictions and paperwork you have to deal with to exchange money in mainland China. One competitive place to exchange money is Chungking Mansion in Tsim Sha Tsui, with a high density of Pakistani and Indian currency sellers. However, the money changers at the entrance generally have worse rates than those in the interior.

Exchange rates for Hong Kong dollar

As of June 2026:

- US\$1 ≈ \$7.8
- €1 ≈ \$9.1
- UK£1 ≈ \$10.5
- CA\$1 ≈ \$5.6
- Japanese ¥100 ≈ \$4.9
- Chinese ¥1 ≈ \$1.1
- SG\$1 ≈ \$6.1
- South Korean ₩1,000 ≈ \$5.2
- NT\$10 ≈ \$2.4

Exchange rates fluctuate. Current rates for these and other currencies are available from XE.com (<https://www.xe.com/currency/hkd-hong-kong-dollar>)



International Commerce Centre,
Kowloon

Try to avoid changing money at the airport, train stations, hotels, or at street blocks or buildings with only one exchange stall since the rates offered there are usually less favourable. Street money exchange vendors will often offer different rates and you may be able to save around 10% if you can compare several different places rather than using the first one you see.

Getting money by withdrawing with Automated Teller Machines (ATMs) or debit cards may have competitive exchange rates and most big banks do not charge an ATM usage fee, though your banks may impose their own fees (including foreign exchange markups and fixed withdrawal fees). Some smaller banks do not accept ATM cards from overseas customers though. The best banks for foreign tourists to use are HSBC, Hang Seng and Standard Chartered, and ATMs from those banks are widespread and can be found at any MTR station and along every major street corner.

Other than the \$10 banknote, all others are issued by multiple banks in Hong Kong, namely the Hong Kong and Shanghai Banking Corporation (HSBC), Standard Chartered Bank and the Bank of China. Although they have slightly different designs, notes of the same denomination have the same colour and all of them can be used anywhere in Hong Kong. They come in denominations of \$10, \$20, \$50, \$100, \$500 and \$1000. Some shops do not accept \$1000 notes due to counterfeiting concerns.

Coins come in units of \$10, \$5, \$2, \$1, 50¢, 20¢ and 10¢. Typically you will want to avoid change less than \$1 because there are not many things to buy with coins under that, and some shops may refuse them outright. An Octopus Card is the best way to avoid dealing with large amounts of small change.

The Octopus cards you use for transport (see [#Get around](#) section) can also be used to pay for items at many fast food chains, supermarkets, and convenience stores. Mobile payment like Alipay, WeChat Pay and PayMe (provided by HSBC) is gaining traction among merchants, but a large number of smaller shops still accept cash only. For Alipay and WeChat Pay, some might also only accept their Hong Kong versions instead of Mainland Chinese versions.

The Queen's head

You might occasionally encounter coins issued before 1997 that feature the former head of state, Queen Elizabeth II of the United Kingdom. Although they remain legal tender in Hong Kong, they are becoming rarer and make for a great collectible — after all, the era and its representing monarch are already history.

ATMs are ubiquitous. They universally accept Visa, MasterCard, and now UnionPay, and to a lesser degree Maestro and Cirrus. No ATMs accept American Express. Credit/debit card use is common in most shops for major purchases. Most retailers accept Visa, MasterCard, and American Express. Maestro debit cards are not widely accepted by retailers.

Sometimes, the merchant can give you a choice of whether to charge your credit card purchase directly to your home currency or Hong Kong dollars. You should always charge your card in Hong Kong dollars and let your bank perform the conversion.

The 'chip and pin' system for credit card authorisation is not used as extensively in Hong Kong as elsewhere. Many retailers use contactless communications for foreign-issued cards and if used for small purchases, a signature is not required. Apple Pay and Google Pay acceptance is near universal within the same venues that take contactless cards.

Banking

Opening a bank account in Hong Kong is a straightforward process, requiring a proof of address and a corresponding ID. A Hong Kong identification card (of any type) will make the process much easier, although foreign visitors are allowed to open bank accounts as well using their foreign address. Banks will almost always have English speaking staff available.

Some banks can also provide accounts and UnionPay credit cards in the Chinese RMB currency, which can then be used when travelling in mainland China. In addition, Hong Kong bank accounts support PromptPay QR code payments in Thailand, which makes onward travel there easier as well.

Costs

Hong Kong is expensive by Asian standards, with the cost of accommodation especially high. A comfortable mid-range hotel room will cost at least \$800 a night, although those who are really on a shoe-string budget could find something for less than \$200 for just a bed in a hostel.

Transport is however relatively cheap, with most public transport journeys costing just a few dollars. Even taxis won't break the bank with short journeys costing about \$30, although crossing the harbour will add another \$80 to your tab.

Eating out in Hong Kong is generally cheaper than in Western countries, and prices start from about \$30 per serve for a basic meal of porridge or noodles, although in mid-range restaurants, \$200–300 per head is common. At the other end of the spectrum, fine dining can also be very expensive, and prices on the order of \$1000 per head or more are not unheard of.

Finally it is worth noting that Hong Kong does not have a sales tax and therefore prices for moderately expensive items (such as imported shampoo, mobile phones etc.) will generally be less than in China, Europe and other countries with sales tax.

Tipping

As a general rule, tipping is *not* customary in Hong Kong, though people will not reject any tips you care to hand them. Tipping is a matter of personal choice, but locals usually do not leave a tip. It is common for bar and restaurant owners to keep some, or all, of the money given as tips to waiters.

In cheaper restaurants, tipping is not expected at all and it will be considered unusual not to take all your change. In medium-to-upmarket restaurants, a 10% service charge is often compulsorily added to your bill (i.e. the prices of food and beverage items you see on the menu do *not* calculate and include service charge yet). You may, at your own discretion, choose to tip on top of that if the service was exemplary; to give it more chance of reaching the staff, tips should be given in cash and not as additions to a credit card bill. It is also common for mid range Chinese restaurants to give you peanuts, tea and towels and add a small charge to the bill. Known as "cha-sui money" (money for tea and water), it is considered to be common practice, so unless the charge is excessive, tourists should accept it as part of the cost of the meal. Sometimes, restaurants will deliberately give customers change in coins, when notes could be given; it is your choice whether to take all your change or leave a small tip.

Tipping is not expected in taxis but passengers will often round up the fare to the nearest dollar. During a typhoon, when any loss is not covered by insurance, a tip will be expected, or the taxi driver will ask you to pay a surcharge. In hotels, a guest is also expected to tip at least \$10–20 for room service, and porters also expect \$10–20 for carrying your bags. Bathroom attendants in luxury restaurants and clubs might also expect you to leave a few coins, but it's socially acceptable not to tip.

Do not under any circumstances try to offer a tip to a government employee, especially police officers; this is regarded as bribery and is strictly illegal.

Exceptionally, on important occasions, such as a wedding party or similar big gala event, local people hosting such events do tip substantially more than ten percent of the total bill. The money is put into a red packet (called 利是 *lai si* in Cantonese) and given to the manager.

Shop

Main article: [Shopping in Hong Kong](#)

Fierce competition, no sales tax and many wealthy consumers all add up to make Hong Kong an excellent destination for shopping. Choices are plentiful at competitive prices. Lookout for watches, camping equipment, digital items and luxury cosmetics. Popular shopping items include consumer electronics, custom clothing, shoes, camping equipment, jewellery, expensive brand name goods, Chinese antiques, toys and Chinese herbs/medicine. There's also a wide choice of Japanese, Korean, American and European clothing and cosmetics but prices are generally higher than in their respective home countries.

Eat

Individual listings can be found in Hong Kong's [district](#) articles

See also: [Hong Kong Culinary Tour](#), [Chinese cuisine](#), and [Western food in Asia](#)

Cuisine plays an important part in many peoples' lives in Hong Kong. Not only is it a showcase of various regional Chinese cuisines, but there are also excellent Asian and Western options, and creative fusion between the various cuisines. Although Western food is often adapted to local tastes, Hong Kong is a good place for homesick travellers who have had enough of Chinese food.

Due to its history as part of that region, unsurprisingly, much of the local cuisine in Hong Kong is very similar to that of neighbouring [Guangdong](#). That being said, over a century of British rule means that the British have also left their mark on the local cuisine, with cakes and pastries being fairly popular among locals. Hong Kongers are also somewhat less adventurous than their fellow Cantonese speakers in mainland China, with several exotic ingredients such as



Hot and iced Hong Kong tea



dog and cat meat being banned in Hong Kong. Indian immigrants brought over by the British have also left their mark on Hong Kong cuisine, and **curry** (咖喱) is a popular condiment. While authentic Indian curries can certainly be found, Hong Kong curries are generally adapted for the Cantonese palate, with the spice level dialed down drastically.

It is also possible to find cuisine from practically every part of China, as many famous chefs fled from the mainland to Hong Kong to escape persecution by the communists in the aftermath of the Chinese Civil War. In particular, the Hakkas and Teochews have left a significant impact on Hong Kong's culinary culture, and there is no shortage of good Hakka and Teochew restaurants for those who have grown weary of Cantonese food.

You may meet some local people who haven't cooked at home for a decade. Locals love to go out to eat since it is much more practical than socializing in crowded spaces at home. A long queue can be a local sport outside many good restaurants during peak hours. Normally, you need to register first, get a ticket and wait for empty seats. Reservations are usually only an option in upmarket restaurants.

Eating etiquette

Chinese food is generally eaten with chopsticks. However, restaurants serving Western food usually provide a knife, fork and spoon. Do not stick your chopsticks vertically into a bowl of rice, as this is reminiscent of incense sticks burning at the temple and has connotations of wishing death on those around you. In addition, chopsticks should not be used to move bowls and plates or make any noise. Dishes in smaller eateries might not come with a serving spoon, although staff will usually provide one if you request.

A few Hong Kong customs to be aware of:

- To thank the person who pours your tea Cantonese style, **tap two or three fingers** on the table three times. The legend suggests a story involving a Chinese emperor travelling incognito and his loyal subjects wanting to kowtow (bow) to him without blowing their cover — hence the "finger kowtow".
- If you want more tea in the pot, leave the lid open, and it will be refilled.
- It is not unusual for customers to **rinse their plates and utensils with hot tea** before starting their meal, and a bowl is often provided for this very purpose. This is due to the fact that cheaper restaurants may often have washing residues on dishes or utensils.
- Except for very expensive places, there is no real dress code in Hong Kong. You will often see people in suits and others in t-shirts in the same restaurant.

See also [Chinese table manners](#) for more details. While there are some minor differences, much of traditional Chinese dining etiquette applies to Hong Kong too.



Cantonese fast food: winter melon soup (冬瓜盅) with steamed beef cake (蒸牛肉餅), rice and tea



Cantonese lou fo tong (老火湯 slow-boiled soup) such as pig lung & almond soup is enjoyed by many locals

Local foods, eating establishments, and costs

You can usually tell how cheap (or expensive) the food is from the decor of the restaurant. Menus are not always displayed outside restaurants and English menus are not available at budget restaurants. Restaurants in Soho in Central, in 5-star restaurants, or in other high-rent areas are usually more expensive than restaurants that are off the beaten path. It is easy to find places selling mains for well under \$80, offering both local and international food. Local fast food chains such as Café de Coral (大家樂) (<https://www.cafedecoralfastfood.com/?lang=en>) and Fairwood (大快活) (<https://www.fairwood.com.hk/en>) offer meals for \$30–50, with standardised English menus for easy ordering. Mid-range restaurants generally charge in excess of \$100 for mains. At the top end, fine dining restaurants, such as Felix or Aqua, can easily see you leave with a bill in excess of \$1500 (including entrées (appetisers), mains, desserts and drinks). If your budget allows for it, Hong Kong is undoubtedly one of, if not the world's best places to experience Chinese-style fine dining.

Tap water is typically **not** served and you will need to buy bottled water from most restaurants instead.

Dim sum

Dim sum (點心), literally means 'to touch (your) heart', is possibly the best known Cantonese dish. Served at breakfast and lunch, these delicately prepared morsels of Cantonese cuisine are often served with Chinese tea.

Dim Sum comes in countless variations with a huge price range from \$8 to more than \$100 per order. Common items include steamed shrimp dumplings (蝦餃 *har gau*), pork dumplings (燒賣 *siu mai*) and barbecued pork buns (叉燒包 *char siu bau*), the first two being obligatory for local diners whenever they eat dim sum. Expect more choice in upmarket restaurants. One pot of tea with two dishes, called *yak chung liang gin* is a typical serving for breakfast.

Siu Mei

Siu mei (燒味) is a general name for roast meats made in a Hong Kong style, including roasted crispy pork belly (燒肉 *siu yuk*), barbecued pork (叉燒 *char siu*), roast duck (燒鴨 *siu aap*) or soy sauce chicken (豉油雞 *si yau gai*). With the addition of a slightly crispy honey sauce layer, the final taste is of char siu a unique, deep barbecue flavour. Rice with roasted pork, roasted duck,



Seafood Street in Sai Kung, New Territories



Live seafood tanks, Sai Kung



A selection of *dim sum*. Clockwise from top left: shrimp dumplings (蝦餃 *har gau*), chicken and vegetable congee (粥 *juk*), jasmine tea, steamed dumplings, barbecued pork buns (叉燒包 *char siu bau*), rice noodle rolls with soy sauce (腸粉 *cheong fun*)

pork with a crisp crackling, or Fragrant Queen's chicken (香妃雞), are common dishes that are enduring favourites for many, including local superstars. It is recommended to taste the roasted pork with rice in 'Sun-Can' of PolyU.

Congee

Cantonese congee (粥 *juk*) is a thin porridge made with rice boiled in water. Served at breakfast, lunch or supper, the best version is as soft as 'floss', it takes up to 10 hours to cook the porridge to reach this quality. Congee is usually eaten with savoury deep-fried Chinese doughnuts (油炸鬼 *yau char kway*) and steamed rice pastry (腸粉 *cheong fun*) which often has a meat or vegetable filling.

Hong Kong has several restaurant chains that specialise in congee, but none of them have earned the word-of-mouth respect from local gourmets. The best congee places are usually in older districts, often owned by elderly people who are patient enough to spend hours making the best floss congee.

Noodles

When asked what food makes Hong Kong people feel at home, wonton noodles (雲吞麵) are a popular answer. Wonton are dumplings usually made from minced prawn but may contain small amounts of pork.

Rice pastry is also a popular dish from southern China. Found particularly in Teochew and Hokkien areas in China, its popularity is widespread throughout east Asia. In Hong Kong, it is usually served in soup with beef and fish balls and sometimes with deep-fried crispy fish skins.

Two-dish rice

The classic working-class meal in Hong Kong, this consists of white rice with numerous other traditional Cantonese dishes to choose from, with customers typically picking two to three dishes, hence the name "two-dish rice" (兩餸飯 *léuhng sung faahn*). As the dishes are rarely labelled, customers typically choose their dishes by pointing and saying 呢個 (*nēi go*, meaning "this one"), giving it its nickname "this this rice". Once looked down upon and considered to be "poor man's food", its popularity skyrocketed during the COVID-19 pandemic, when dine-in establishments were forced to close, and many two-dish rice stalls are now famous among locals for specific dishes. Do not expect much English proficiency at such establishments, but if you can find a way to communicate, these are excellent places to have an affordable meal, with prices typically being around \$40-60, depending on the number of dishes you pick.

Tong Sui

A popular Cantonese dessert is a sweet soup called *tong sui* (糖水, literally sugar water). Popular versions are usually made with black sesame paste (芝麻糊), walnuts (核桃糊) or sago (西米露) which are usually sticky in texture. Other traditional ones include red bean paste (紅豆沙), green bean paste (綠豆沙) and tofu pudding (豆腐花). *Lo ye* (撈野) is a similar dish. Juice is put into an ultra-cold pan to make an ice paste, it is usually served with fresh fruit and sago.

Tea cafes & tea time

A uniquely Hong Kong-style eatery that has made waves elsewhere in Asia is the ***cha chaan teng*** (茶餐廳), literally "tea cafe", but offering fusion fast food that happily mixes Western and Eastern fare: innovations include macaroni soup with ham, instant noodles with spam and egg, Hong Kong-style French toast, and baked rice or spaghetti with meat sauce and cheese. Usually a wide selection of drinks is also available, almost always including the popular tea-and-coffee mix *yuen yeung* (鴛鴦), and perhaps more oddities (to the Western palate) like boiled Coke with ginger or iced coffee with lemon. Orders are usually recorded on a chit at your table and you pay at the cashier as you leave.

Hot milk tea Hong Kong style

You might expect that after more than a century of colonial rule tea might be served British style - well, almost. Order a cup of hot Hong Kong milk tea (熱奶茶) in a traditional cafe and what you will get will be a cup of the strongest brew imaginable. With the addition of evaporated milk, this is not a drink for the faint-hearted.

Showing signs of British colonial influence, tea time (下午茶 *hah ígh chàh*) plays an important role in Hong Kong's stressful office life. Usually starting at 2PM to 3PM, a typical tea set goes with a cup of 'silk-stocking' tea, egg tarts and sandwiches with either minced beef, egg or ham, but without vegetables and cheese.

Hong Kong's version of milk tea shares a similar taste with Malaysia's *teh tarik*. A distinctive feature of Hong Kong-style milk tea is the sackcloth bag that is used to filter the tea leaves, which looks like silk stockings after being dyed with tea, giving the name 'silk-stocking milk tea'. Milk tea, to some Hong Kong people, is an important indicator on the quality of a restaurant. If a restaurant fails to serve reasonably good milk tea, locals might be very harsh with their criticism. Yuanyang is also a popular drink mixed with milk tea and coffee.

A signal to tell you teatime has come is a small queue lining up in a bakery to buy egg tarts (蛋撻, a teatime snack with outer pastry crust and filled with egg custard). Don't attempt to make a fool of yourself by telling people that the egg tart was brought to Hong Kong by the British - many locals are assertive in claiming sovereignty over their egg tarts. When a long-established egg tart shop in Central was closed due to skyrocketing rental payments, it became the SAR's main news and many people came to help the owners look for a new place. Hong Kong egg tarts differ from the Macau version mainly in their crust; the Hong Kong version typically uses a crumbly crust like English custard tarts, while the Macau version typically uses a flaky crust like the Portuguese *pastel de nata*.

For those who wish to have an authentic British high tea experience, the colonial **Peninsula Hotel** (<https://www.peninsula.com/en/default>) is one of the best places in Asia to do so.

To stuff your stomach in a grassroots Chaa Chan Teng (茶餐廳) (local tea restaurant), expect to pay \$15–28 for milk, tea or coffee, \$15–18 for a toast, and \$39–60 for a dish of rice with meats. Wonton noodles generally cost \$35–45.

Street food

The cheapest food is in the popular street stalls. Most of the people working there do not speak much English and there is often no English on the menu. However, if you could manage to communicate, street-style eating is an excellent way to experience local food. Point, use fingers (or Cantonese numbers) and smile. They're usually willing to help. Local specialities include curry fish balls (咖喱魚蛋), fake shark fin soup (碗仔翅) made with beans and vermicelli noodles,

egg waffle (雞蛋仔), fried three filled treasures (煎釀三寶, vegetable filled with fish meat), stinky tofu (臭豆腐), fried intestines on a stick, fried squid or octopus and various meats on sticks (such as satay style chicken).

Fast food

Most major fast food eateries are popular in Hong Kong and have reasonable prices. McDonald's sells a Happy Meal set for \$20–25.

Seafood

Seafood (海鮮 *hoi sin*) is very popular and is widely available. The best places to eat seafood include Sai Kung, Sam Shing, Po Doi O and Lau Fau Shan in the New Territories and Hong Kong's islands, particularly Lamma and Cheung Chau, abound with seafood restaurants. Seafood is not cheap. Prices range from \$200 per head for a very basic dinner, to \$300–500 for better choices and much more for the best on offer.

Expect to find a mismatch between the high prices for the food and the quality of the restaurant. Sometimes the best food is served in the most basic eateries where tables maybe covered in cheap plastic covers rather than a more formal tablecloth. Often, Cantonese people value the food more than the decor. If one of your travelling companions does not like seafood, don't panic, many seafood restaurants have extensive menus that cater for all tastes. A number of seafood restaurants specialise in high quality roast chicken that is especially flavoursome. Many exotic delicacies like abalone, conch and bamboo clam can be found for sale in many seafood restaurants but you might want to avoid endangered species such as shark and juvenile fish.



Seafood



Exotic meats

While Hong Kong has long banned dog and cat meat and has strict rules on importing many meats of wild animals, snake meat is commonly seen in winter in different restaurants that bear the name "Snake King". Served in a sticky soup, it is believed to warm your body.

There's an ongoing debate over the consumption of shark fin in Hong Kong, which is the biggest importer of this exotic cuisine. Commonly served at wedding parties and other important dining events, shark fin is served in a carefully prepared stew at as much as \$1000/bowl. The consumption of shark fin is controversial due to the inhumane manner in which the fins are collected. Sharks are removed from the ocean, their fins are cut off, and they are discarded back into the ocean *still alive* to die a slow unpleasant death. To quell your curiosity, imitation shark fin soup is available, and reportedly indistinguishable from the real thing.

Besides exotic meats, you will also see chicken feet, pig's noses and ears, lungs, stomachs, duck's heads, various types of intestines, livers, kidneys, black pudding (blood jelly) and duck's tongues on the Chinese dining tables.

International cuisine

Due to the large number of foreign residents in Hong Kong, there are many restaurants that serve authentic international cuisine at all price levels. This includes various types of Japanese, Thai, Indian, Malaysian, American and European foods. These can often be found in, though not restricted to, entertainment districts such as Lan Kwai Fong, Soho or Knutsford Terrace. Of these, Soho is probably the best for eating as Lan Kwai Fong is primarily saturated with bars and clubs. Chungking Mansions in Tsim Sha Tsui is known to locals for having a high concentration of affordable Indian and African restaurants. Top chefs are often invited or try to make their way to work in Hong Kong.

Local Western food

While authentic Western food is certainly available at higher-end restaurants, much of the Western food in Hong Kong has been localised to the point of being hardly recognisable to Westerners, resulting in a unique style known as "**soy sauce Western**" (豉油西餐). This style of Western food is mainly sold at cha chaan teng, though a local mid-range restaurant chain famous for this style of cuisine is **Tai Ping Koon** (太平館), best known to locals for a dish called "Swiss chicken wings" (瑞士雞翼).

Home-dining

Home-dining is catching on to be a very popular trend in Hong Kong. BonAppetour (<http://www.bonappetour.com/s/Hong-Kong>) is a great way to discover local chefs who would love to have you over for an evening dinner. It's a great way to make friends over home-made food, and company.

Barbecue

Barbecue (BBQ) meals are a popular local pastime. Many areas feature free public barbecue pits where everybody roasts their own food, usually with long barbeque forks. It's not just sausages and burgers - the locals enjoy cooking a variety of things at BBQ parties, such as fish, beef meatballs, pork meatballs, chicken wings, and so on. A good spot is the Southern Hong Kong Island, where almost every beach is equipped with many free BBQ spots. Just stop by a supermarket and buy food, drinks and BBQ equipment. The best spots are Shek O (under the trees at the left hand side of the beach) and Big Wave Bay.

Kau Wah Keng (九華徑) village in Lai King, New Territories was home to some private-run BBQ sites that provide food upon payment. These BBQ sites are unlicensed, and authorities had clamped down on their operation during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Wet markets

Wet markets are still prevalent. Freshness is a key ingredient to all Chinese food, so frozen meat and vegetables are frowned upon, and most markets display freshly butchered **beef and pork** (with entrails), live fish, and more **exotic shellfish, frogs**, turtles and sea snails. Local people often go to the market everyday to buy fresh ingredients, just like the restaurants.

Cooked food centres

Cooked food centres are often found in the same building as some of the indoor wet markets. Tables that used to be on the street have been swept into sterile concrete buildings. Inside, the atmosphere is like a food court without the frills. Cooked food centres provide economic solutions to diners, but you might need to take along a Cantonese speaker, or be brave.

Dietary restrictions

As many people in Hong Kong's South Asian community are Hindu or Muslim, your best bet for religious diets that fall into those categories are restaurants that serve those communities. The Islamic Trust (<https://www.islamictrusthk.org/>) is Hong Kong's halal certification body, and Muslims visitors can contact them for more information. Due to the small size of Hong Kong's Jewish community, kosher food is rare; contact the Ohel Leah Synagogue (<https://ohelleah.org/>) for more information.

Vegetarians should look for specialist vegetarian restaurants that primarily serve devout Buddhists (look for the characters 素 or 齋, or the 卍 symbol, in this context a Buddhist symbol). Some Buddhist temples may also sell vegetarian food during the weekends or various Buddhist festivals. As Chinese Buddhist vegetarian food does not usually make use of eggs or dairy products, it is almost always suitable for **vegans**. Remembering the Cantonese phrase 我食齋 (*ngóh sihk jāai*), telling that you are vegetarian, also goes a long way in getting your point across.

People with **allergies** will have difficulty in Hong Kong, as awareness of common allergies is poor. Gluten-free diets in particular are very hard to come by as coeliac disease is very rare in Hong Kong, and much of Hong Kong's local cuisine makes heavy use of soy sauce. **Dairy** is somewhat more common in Hong Kong than in mainland China due to the stronger British influence, but nevertheless does not feature very prominently in traditional Cantonese cuisine, so lactose-intolerant people should not have any major issues finding something suitable for them. On the bright side, avoiding **nuts** is fairly easy, as they are uncommon in Hong Kong cuisine.

Drink

Tea

Main article: Tea

As with the rest of China, tea is a popular beverage in Hong Kong, and is served at practically every eatery. Chinese teas are the most commonly drunk in Hong Kong, but there is also a distinct Hong Kong-style milk tea that is served in *chaa chaan teng*, and traditional English milk tea can be found in higher-end Western restaurants. In summer 'Ice Lemon Tea' is a common option that is rather bitter and needs some syrup to counter this.

Alcohol

Hong Kong does not have a culture of heavy drinking, and there are many neighbourhoods without much in the way of a bar or pub. Drinking alcohol with food is acceptable, but there is no expectation to order alcohol with your meal in any restaurant. A number of popular restaurants

do not sell alcohol because of a licence restriction. In addition, alcohol in Hong Kong is expensive, and half a pint of beer in a bar or restaurant costs about \$70 (in 2025).

Lan Kwai Fong (Central), **Wan Chai**, and **Knutsford Terrace** (Tsim Sha Tsui) are the three main drinking areas where locals, expats, and tourists come together.

Lan Kwai Fong is known for its lively, block party atmosphere, attracting many expats and tourists. The rooftop bar Faye on the 25th floor of the California Tower at Lan Kwai Fong is a hotspot for European exchange students. Some clubs in Lan Kwai Fong enforce dress codes, and tourists are expected to comply. As a rule, avoid wearing shorts or pants that are above knee length. Just a short walk away, **Peel Street** and the surrounding SoHo area have emerged as the preferred hangout for long-term expats, offering more relaxed bars, better cocktails, and a more laid-back atmosphere than the tourist-heavy clubs of LKF.



Lan Kwai Fong at night



Wan Chai is known less for its drinks than for its dated seediness. Once the centre of nightlife for US servicemen, today it is still popular with a certain crowd of older expats and bar girls, but it has a sleazy reputation and is generally avoided by younger locals and newer expats looking for a more contemporary vibe. Girlie bars or hostess bars are bars in which attractive bar girls drink and flirt with male patrons in exchange for tips. Cover charges and drink prices at these establishments are usually exorbitant, and you will be pressured to buy drinks for the bar girls. Generally speaking, the bar girls will not leave the bar with you; they are professional flirts, not prostitutes.

Another popular nightlife option is Wednesday nights at **Happy Valley Racecourse**. Go past the fancy luxury cars and oligarchs to the standing section with a vibrant social scene, drawing large crowds for horse racing, casual drinking, and a lively party atmosphere. The races usually conclude around 10:30 pm, making it a perfect mid-week night out.

Gay bars and clubs are concentrated in Central, Sheung Wan, Causeway Bay and Tsim Sha Tsui (TST). The quality of these venues varies considerably and may disappoint those expecting something on the level of London, Paris or New York.

The minimum age for drinking alcohol is 18 years. There is usually a requirement for young adults to prove their age, especially when going to a nightclub. The accepted ID in clubs is either your passport or a Hong Kong ID card. Photocopies are rarely accepted due to minors using fake documents.

Drinking out in Hong Kong can be expensive. Beer usually starts from \$50 for a pint and more in a bar popular among expats. However, away from the tourist trail, some Chinese restaurants may have a beer promotion aimed at meeting the needs of groups of diners. In cooked food centres, usually found at the wet markets, young women are often employed to promote a particular brand of beer. Convenience stores and supermarkets sell a reasonable range of drinks.

During Wednesdays and Thursdays, Ladies night applies in some bars in Wan Chai and Lan Kwai Fong, which in most cases means that women can enter bars and clubs for free, and in some rare cases also get their drinks paid for the night. On weekends, several bars and clubs in these areas also have an open bar for some of the night, which means you can drink as much as you like.

San Miguel (Cantonese name: Seng Lik), Tsing Tao (Ching Dou), Carlsberg (Ga Si Bak), Blue Girl (Lam Mui), Heineken (Hei Lik) and Sol are popular in the town. There is no longer any tax on wine or beer in Hong Kong.

Sleep

Individual listings can be found in Hong Kong's district articles

With more than 50,000 rooms available, Hong Kong offers a huge choice of accommodation from shockingly cheap digs to super luxury. However, budget travellers who are spoiled by cheap prices elsewhere in [Asia](#) are often shocked that the accommodation cost in Hong Kong is closer to that of London and New York.

A 3% hotel accommodation tax is levied on hotel rooms, excluding service charges. You will pay the tax when you pay for hotel rooms.

For long-term accommodation, be prepared to splurge as real estate prices in Hong Kong are among the highest in the world, and many locals are forced to live in cramped "shoebox" apartments due to the astronomical rents in the city.

Budget

While it is possible to get a dorm bed for \$120–150, a single room for \$270–400, and a double room for \$400–500, you should not expect anything in these rooms except a bed, with barely enough space in the room to open the door. Accommodation with *reasonable* space, decoration, and cleanness is usually priced from \$150–200 for a dorm bed, \$450–600 for a single room, \$700 for a double room, and \$800 for a triple room.

Most cheap guesthouses are found along Nathan Road between Tsim Sha Tsui and Mong Kok. Expect a tiny, undecorated room with just enough room for a bed. Bathrooms are often shared and noise could be a problem for light sleepers (not all customers are interested in sleeping). Be sure to read the online reviews before booking as bed bugs, dirty beds, and unclean bathrooms have been reported. Keep your expectations as realistically low as possible.

Popular guesthouse clusters are inside the 17-floor **1 Chungking Mansions** (Nathan Road 36-44) (重慶大廈 in Chinese, nicknamed Chungking Jungles by some local people), Mirador Mansions (美麗都大廈) in Tsim Sha Tsui, and New Lucky House (華豐大廈) (15 Jordan Road). These towers are all in the city center and close to the buses to/from the airport. While these towers are regarded as slums by the locals, if you ignore the fake watch sellers and disturbing pimps, they are well-patrolled and safe.

Another cluster of hostels and guesthouses can be found on Paterson Street near Causeway Bay. While not as central as the mansions, the internet connections are more reliable and the rooms are generally clean. However, they are still small and cramped. Do not expect a great atmosphere or spacious rooms.

Notice that some drab "guesthouses", especially those in Kowloon Tong, Mong Kok, and Causeway Bay, may actually be *love hotels*.

The Hong Kong Youth Hostel Association (<http://www.yha.org.hk/>) operates 7 youth hostels. All of them are outside of the city and cost \$100–\$300 to reach via taxi when public transport service is not operating. All but the one on Hong Kong Island also have strict curfew rules and require guests to leave the site from 10AM to 4PM (1PM-3PM on public holidays). Free shuttle bus service is provided by several hostels but the service stops at 10:30PM.

The government advises travellers to stay in hostels with licences, this website may help you a lot: The Office of Licensing Authority (<http://www.hadla.gov.hk/>) maintains an online list of licensed accommodation establishments.

There are 41 camping sites (http://www.afcd.gov.hk/english/country/cou_vis/cou_vis_cam/co_u_vis_cam_cam/cou_vis_cam_cam.html) in Hong Kong. The facilities are on a "first-come-first-served" basis and places are booked quickly during weekends and public holidays. You are not allowed to camp other than in a designated camp site (identified by the sign board erected by the Country and Marine Parks Authority) and this rule is strictly enforced.

Mid-range

If the mansions and hostels are too cramped for you, Hong Kong is a good place to spend a bit extra and get a proper hotel room. Many rooms in basic business hotels in the city center can be had for \$700 per night. Rooms at mid-ranged hotels in Hong Kong tend to be clean but cramped.

Splurge

For affluent travellers, Hong Kong houses some of the best world class hotels that run a fierce competition for your wallets by offering pick-up service by helicopter, a Michelin star restaurant, and extravagant spas. Major international chains, including four- and five-star hotels, are also well-represented. Prices start from around \$1,500, depending on the season.

Stay safe

Hong Kong is one of the safest cities in the world, with a large high-density population with diverse socio-economic backgrounds managed very effectively. The city experienced significant large-scale protests against new legislation with increasingly violent clashes with police between 2014 and 2019. The arbitrariness and broad applicability of the **National Security Law** imposed by China in 2020 has ended most public protest.

Crime and other emergency services

Even female travellers usually do not encounter any problems roaming the streets alone at night. Violent crime is extremely rare, though petty crime occurs from time to time. Pickpockets operate in crowded areas; be particularly careful on public transport during peak hours.

The **Hong Kong Police Force** (<https://www.police.gov.hk/>) is Hong Kong's law enforcement agency. Most officers wear light blue uniforms, though higher-ranking officers wear white uniforms. All police officers are required to carry their warrant cards while on duty, and must present it to members of the public on request. English proficiency among lower ranking police officers can be limited, though they will always have English-speaking interpreters on call to assist you. Police corruption is exceedingly rare. Bribery is a crime that is punishable by imprisonment.

Hong Kong films have often portrayed triads (Chinese organised crime syndicates) as gun-wielding gangsters who fear nobody, but that only happens in the movies. Gang violence does occur, but is generally limited to rival triads. Stay away from the triads by avoiding loan sharks and illegal betting, and they will not bother you.



Police officer in uniform

Call **999** when you urgently need help from the police, fire and ambulance services. 999 operators can speak English, and in case if you don't know your current location, you can be located by finding your nearest lamppost and replying the lamppost's number. The police should show up within 10 minutes in most cases. If you are deaf or have speech impairment, you can report your emergencies by SMS to **992** with your registered phone, which requires *registration* at a police station beforehand.

The 999 system, local police stations and reporting centres may be *inaccessible* during protests and incidents. Dial the following emergency numbers in case when the 999 system is down:

- Fire Services Department: ☎ [+852-2723-2233](tel:+852-2723-2233) for fire or medical emergencies
- Hong Kong St. John Ambulance: ☎ [+852-1878-000](tel:+852-1878-000) with only 3 stations throughout Hong Kong, it may take a longer time for arrival.

For non-emergency police assistance, call ☎ [+852-2527-7177](tel:+852-2527-7177). There is also a hotline that serves Japanese travellers at ☎ [+852-2529-0000](tel:+852-2529-0000). If you received suspected scam calls, you can call ☎ 18222 (domestic) to receive advice.

National security legislation



Note: The National Security Law and the Safeguarding National Security Ordinance (also known as Article 23) can be interpreted broadly: anyone — foreigners included — who has criticised the Hong Kong or Chinese governments is at risk of arrest and transfer to mainland China for prosecution under mainland law.

While there is no law that forbids foreigners from participating protests and demonstrations, they are *strongly discouraged* from doing so. Foreigner involvement could result in heightened police attention, and may lead to National Security Law charges if the authorities believe your involvement constitutes collusion with foreign elements.

(Information last updated 04 Sep 2025)

Promoting the independence of any region within China's territorial claim, including Hong Kong, is *illegal*, punishable with a lengthy prison sentence up to life. Forbidden themes include documentaries about the 2019–2020 protests, artwork criticising the Chinese government, and photos depicting the police force in a negative light. Any speech that "incites hatred or subversion" or advocates sanctions against the Hong Kong or Chinese governments is also illegal; this has been interpreted broadly by the police, to include any criticism against the government that the authorities may find objectionable.

Personal attacks against police officers are also deemed seditious by the courts. Avoid displaying symbols that have been adopted by the independence movement, even if they were not designed for the purpose; these include the old colonial flag, and the British and American flags and national anthems.

Defendants under the National Security Law can be sent to mainland China for trial, and there are concerns about arbitrary enforcement of the law. The American, British, Australian and Canadian governments have issued warnings.

July 1 is a public holiday that commemorates the handover to China, but this day became a symbolic day of protest every year. Venues for protests (such as Victoria Park) are cordoned off by the police, and police will arrest anyone at the slightest suspicion that they are making political advocacy during such days.

Legal matters

Disrespecting the Chinese flag, emblem and anthem, along with the Hong Kong regional flag and emblem are punishable by 3 years of imprisonment.

Everyone over the age of 16 is required to carry identification, which for foreigners means a passport, but a foreign identity card or photocopy of your passport will likely do; most visitors choose to keep their passport in a safe place. White people are rarely targeted by the police for ID checks. South Asians and Africans are more likely to be targeted.

If you get arrested, you are expected to cooperate with the police in their investigations, and they may search your body and bags. By law, you can demand that the search be conducted in private, and body searches can only be performed by officers of the same sex. You also have the right to silence (to refuse to answer any questions), to contact your consulate, to engage a lawyer (but you will have to pay for one), and to have your lawyer present at your interrogation. The police are obligated to comply with your request but they may detain you for up to 48 hours.

Most travellers who have got into trouble with the authorities are involved with **illicit drugs**. Drug laws are enforced more strictly in Hong Kong than in the West, and possession of even small quantities of drugs, including "soft" drugs like marijuana, will result in immediate arrest

and a prison sentence of up to 7 years, while possession of drug paraphernalia can result in a prison sentence of up to 3 years even if no drugs are found in your possession. Drug trafficking is punishable by up to **life imprisonment** with most traffickers facing lengthy imprisonment. Most Hongkongers tend to have strong negative views against narcotics, including soft drugs such as marijuana. CBD products are classified as dangerous drugs, and possession or import are criminalized as well.

Discrimination is known to happen. People with a good educational background and reputable jobs are usually better treated by the police, while young people, those from developing countries and Western countries with loose regulations on drugs may experience more frequent checks. The police and the government are exempt from the Race Discrimination Ordinance. However, there is a law to ban any form of police brutality, including verbal attacks and any use of foul language. Call ☎ +852-2866-7700, or file an online complaint report (https://www.police.gov.hk/ppp_en/11_useful_info/cap.html) to the Complaints Against Police Office and report the officer's badge number displayed on his/her shoulder. Although the Office is an internal agency of the police, speaking to them is the only way to lodge a complaint if your grievance doesn't involve police corruption.

Traffic

Traffic rules are strictly enforced in Hong Kong. Penalties can be severe, and road conditions are excellent, although road courtesy still has room for improvement. However, fast drivers create higher death tolls when accidents do happen. There is very little leeway for speeding. As little as 5 km/h above the posted speed limit can be ticketed by the police for speeding, though as much as 10 km/h is usually tolerated.

Signage on the roads in Hong Kong is similar to British usage. Zebra lines (zebra crossings) indicate crossing areas for pedestrians and traffic comes from the right. To stay safe, visit the Transport Department's website (http://www.td.gov.hk/en/road_safety/road_users_code/) for complete details.

For crossing without any traffic control, local people usually wait for vehicles to pass first. Vehicles are not required to let pedestrians cross first.

Crossing the road by foot should also be exercised with great care. Traffic in Hong Kong generally moves fast once the signal turns green. An audible aid is played at every intersection. Rapid bells indicate "Walk"; intermittent bells (10 sets of 3 bells) indicate "Do Not Start to Cross"; and slow bells indicate "Do Not Walk".

Jaywalking is an offence and police officers may be out patrolling accident black-spots. It is not uncommon to see local people waiting to cross an empty road - when this happens, you should stay patient and wait because it is possible that they have noticed a police officer patrolling the crossing. The maximum penalty for jaywalking is \$2000.

Tobacco

To discourage smoking, visitors are allowed to carry no more than 19 duty-free cigarettes or 25 g of tobacco products. Offenders can be charged for cigarette

Smoking restrictions

smuggling and be imprisoned for 7 years. No tobacco products are sold in duty-free shops to arriving passengers. Illegal duty-free cigarettes are sold in locations such as in night markets, but both the buyer and seller may be prosecuted. The police and customs service launch frequent raids. Once caught, ignorance is not an accepted defence.

The importation and selling of e-cigarettes, heated cigarettes and herbal cigarettes is an offence punishable by 7 years of imprisonment. It is also an offence to possess these cigarettes in public, in which violators may be fined for \$3,000 or even jailed.

Cigarette prices in Hong Kong are the second highest in Asia, only behind Singapore. Cigarettes of popular brands can cost over \$60 for a 20-pack (2021). There are also some slightly cheaper brands catering for smokers on budget. Hand-rolling tobacco is uncommon and only available in specialty shops.

A smoking-ban includes all indoor areas and a number of outdoor locations such as university campuses, parks, gardens, bus stops, and beaches. The smoking ban includes bars, clubs, and saunas. You are also forbidden to smoke when queueing. If you are under cover, you probably should not be smoking. Expect to pay a substantial fine of up to \$3,000 if caught smoking in the wrong place. There is also a penalty of \$3,000 for dropping cigarette butts.

Corruption

Hong Kong is ranked as one of the least corrupt jurisdictions in the world by Transparency International, comparing favourably with the U.S. and the UK in this regard. Attempts to bribe police officers or civil servants will almost certainly result in arrest and a prison sentence.

Most companies and organisations have strict protocols regarding employees receiving gifts. Offering gifts or money to workers personally as a sign of gratitude might result in more trouble than is worth.

- **1 Independent Commission Against Corruption (<https://www.icac.org.hk/en/home/index.html>)** (廉政公署), ICAC Building, 303 Java Road, North Point, ☎ +852-2526-6366. 24-hour service. Main office of the ICAC. A list of regional offices can also be founded [here](https://www.icac.org.hk/en/rc/channel/ro/index.html) (<https://www.icac.org.hk/en/rc/channel/ro/index.html>). (updated Jun 2020 |)

Hiking

See also: [Hiking](#)

Several hikers have lost their lives in the wilderness. Hikers should equip themselves with detailed hiking maps, a compass, mobile phones, food, and adequate amounts of drinking water.

Most areas of the countryside are covered by mobile phone networks, and as long as there is signal from at least one Hong Kong mobile phone operator, dialing **112** has the same effect of dialing 999 in case of emergency. However in some places where there is no signal or where you can only receive a Mainland Chinese signal, you cannot dial 999, even if roaming services may be available.

Emergency telephones are placed in Country Parks; their locations are clearly marked on all hiking maps. The police also developed HKSOS (<https://www.police.gov.hk/isw/hksos/>), an app that allows you to contact the police even if there is no signal. Trail markers often have codes etched onto the posts, which are marked on hiking maps, and might be marked on Google Maps. They allow precise location by emergency personnel should you require assistance.

Heat stroke is a major problem for hikers who lack experience of walking in a warm climate. If you plan to walk a dog during the hot summer months, remember that dogs are more vulnerable to heat stroke than humans and owners should ensure their pets get adequate rest and water.

The cooler hiking and camping season in October to February is also the time of the year when hill fires are most likely to strike. At the entrances to country parks you will likely observe signs warning you of the current fire risk. With an average of 365 hill fires a year, you should take the risk of fire seriously, dispose of cigarettes and matches appropriately, and don't light fire outside of designated places. Offenders are liable to imprisonment of 1 year and a fine of \$5000.

Snakes are common in the countryside, and some are quite large. Most will move out of your way, but the small bright green ones are poisonous and stay still. Beware of them.

While it's generally very safe to hike, the countryside can provide shelter to illegal immigrants and hermits, and a few cases of hikers being accosted and robbed have been reported. However, the police patrol hiking routes, and most major paths offer the security of fellow hikers. Some popular unofficial hiking trails in the New Territories may pass through the **frontier closed area or military closed area**. The map of the frontier closed area can be found here (https://www.police.gov.hk/info/doc/licensing/closed_area_permit/fcamap.pdf). Permits are required to enter the area, which are not issued to hikers. **Live-firing exercises** are occasionally conducted in the military closed area. Their coordinates are listed at here (<https://www.elegislation.gov.hk/hk/cap196/sch1>). Red flags are erected in the day, and red lights are lit at night during live firing exercises: **stay away from the marked area**. Intruders risk arrest and imprisonment for 2 years, or even injuries from gunfire or unexploded ordnance.

Natural disasters

Typhoons normally occur during the months of May to November, and are particularly prevalent during September. Whenever a typhoon approaches within 800 km (500 mi) of Hong Kong, typhoon warning signal 1 is issued. Signal 3 is issued as the storm approaches. When winds reach speeds of 63–117 kilometres per hour (18–33 m/s), signal 8 is issued, in which the Hong Kong Observatory will issue a pre-signal 8 notice 2 hours before its formal issuance. At typhoon signal 8, most non-essential activities shut down, including shops, restaurants and the transport system, offices and schools. Bus services stop after 2 to 3 hours after the issuance of signal 8, though the MTR maintains limited service. Ferry services are suspended earlier than other transportations — visitors should return to their accommodation as soon as possible if they are dependent on ferries. Some restaurants may continue to operate with reduced manpower and increased price.



Typhoon warning 1 announcement

Signal 9 and 10 will be issued depending on the proximity and intensity of the storm. At typhoon signal 9 and 10, only underground sections of the MTR maintain limited service. Winds may gust at speeds exceeding 220 km/h (140 mph) causing masonry and other heavy objects to fall to the ground. During a typhoon, visitors should heed all warnings very seriously and stay indoors until the storm has passed. If the eye of the storm passes directly over there will be a temporary period of calm followed by a sudden resumption of strong winds from a different direction.

The city's infrastructure has adapted well to typhoons over time, and it is relatively safe place to be in even the most severe typhoons. Locals would be more concerned about when to go to work rather than any real life or property damage, and it is often said the mythical *Lee Ka-Shing Force Field* repels typhoons and forces locals to go to work under bad weather. Effects brought by typhoon are mostly limited tree collapse and traffic disruption, and are over quickly once the storm passes. However, flooding is a particular concern in low-lying areas like Heng Fa Chuen and Tai O.

Some taxis are available during signal 8 or above or black rainstorm. However, unscrupulous taxi drivers will attempt to overcharge passengers, who are often expected to pay up to 100% more when a typhoon strikes. Contrary to common claims, taxi insurance are valid during typhoons or rainstorms, and overcharging is illegal regardless of the circumstances.

Rainstorms also have their own warning system. In increasing order of severity, the levels are amber, red and black. A red or black rainstorm is a serious event and visitors should take refuge inside buildings, and the effects are comparable to a typhoon signal 9 or 10. A heavy rainstorm can turn streets with poor drainage into rivers and cause landslides.

The Hong Kong Observatory (<https://www.weather.gov.hk>) is the best place to get detailed weather information when in Hong Kong. In summer a convectional rainstorm may affect only a small area and give you the false impression that all areas are wet.

Gay and lesbian Hong Kong

Hong Kong is generally a safe place for gay and lesbian travellers, and there are no laws against homosexuality. That said, Hong Kong is generally more conservative than the West, and public displays of affection are still likely to attract curious stares and whispers. Nevertheless, unprovoked violence or harassment of same-sex couples are almost unheard of.

Same-sex marriages are not recognised and there is no anti-discrimination legislation on the grounds of sexuality. The age of consent between two males is 16, while there is no law concerning that between two females.

There is no obvious gay community in daily life. Coming out to strangers or in the office is still regarded as peculiar and most people tend to remain silent on this topic.

Hong Kong Pride (<https://hkpride.net>) holds gay pride events on a weekend in November every year, though the pride parade was replaced by an exhibition in 2023 due to fears of falling afoul of the national security law. The **Hong Kong Lesbian and Gay Film Festival** (<http://www.hklgff.hk>) is one of the longest running LGBT events in Hong Kong, and indeed in Asia. Since 1989, it has brought various international and regional LGBT films to Hong Kong. The festival is usually held in November.

Discrimination

Although violent racist attacks are rare, discriminatory attitudes exist among the population. White people are the least likely to face racism, while discrimination tends to be more widespread against black people, South Asians and Southeast Asians.

Discrimination against Mainland Chinese, even those whose first language is Cantonese, also exists. While violent confrontation is unlikely after the enactment of the national security law, some people remain deeply prejudiced towards Mainlanders.

Prostitution

Prostitution is legal in Hong Kong, but operating a brothel, pimping or advertising for sexual services are illegal. Therefore, much of the sex industry is in the form of "one-woman brothels", where women rent small studio apartments in high-rise buildings to provide sexual services to clients. The industry keeps a low profile, and is not a tourist attraction by any stretch of the term; you are unlikely to come across it unless you specifically go looking for it. Legal sex workers are required to be screened regularly for sexually-transmitted diseases.

Soliciting customers is illegal, so you should avoid the streetwalkers. Not only could they be subject to police raids, but the risk of contracting sexually-transmitted diseases is also higher with them.

Stay healthy

The quality of medical care in Hong Kong is excellent but expensive for foreigners who are not qualified to get a government subsidy. Foreigners on work permits are eligible for subsidised healthcare at public hospitals, but tourists are required to pay the full cost. In cases of emergency, treatment is guaranteed, but you will be billed later if you cannot pay immediately. As a tourist, you are required to pay \$570 for using emergency services (\$100 for Hong Kong residents). Waiting times at hospital emergency rooms can be lengthy for non emergency patients, since people are prioritised according to their situation. If you have a problem making payment in public hospitals, you can apply for financial assistance but you will need to prove your economic status to social workers based in the hospital.

One common cause of sickness is the extreme temperature change between 35 °C humid summer weather outdoors and 18 °C air-conditioned buildings and shopping malls. Some people experience cold symptoms after moving between the two extremes. You are recommended to carry a sweater even in the summer.

Heat stroke is also common when hiking. Carry enough water and take scheduled rests before you feel unwell.

Find a doctor

Healthcare standards in Hong Kong are on par with the West, and finding a reputable doctor is not much of a problem should you get sick. Doctors are of two types: those who practise traditional Chinese medicine and those who practise the Western variety. Both are taken equally

seriously in Hong Kong, but as a visitor the assumption will be to direct you to a Western doctor. Doctors who practise Western medicine almost always speak English fluently, but you may find the receptionist to be more of a challenge.

Seeing a doctor is as easy as walking off the street and making an appointment with the receptionist. Generally you will be seen within an hour or less, but take note of the opening times displayed in the window of the doctor's office. A straightforward consultation for a minor ailment might cost around \$150 to \$500, but your bill will be inclusive of medication. In Hong Kong, it is normal to get your prescribed medicine directly from the doctor. Many clinics and hospitals will accept credit cards, but check beforehand since sometimes only cash is accepted. Expect to pay more if you visit a swanky surgery in Central. Check the directory (<http://www.hkdoctors.org>) maintained by the Hong Kong Medical Association for further information. Help finding general practitioners, medical specialists, and dentists might also be available at your consulate.

On Sundays, finding a doctor can be difficult, and hospital A&E rooms will have very long queues.

Drinking water

Drinkability of water varies around Hong Kong. The Water Board advises that the water is perfectly safe to drink, unless you are in an old building with outdated plumbing and poorly maintained water tanks, but drinking straight from the tap is a very uncommon practice. Most locals prefer to boil and chill their tap water before consumption or to use bottled water.

Bottled water is readily available everywhere for a few dollars, and comes in mineralised and distilled varieties. Hotel rooms typically provide bottled water, which you should use if you are new to the region. Empty bottles should be disposed at recycle bins.

Pollution

Although "Hong Kong" means "fragrant harbour", it is not always so. Air pollution is a significant issue. During periods of very bad air pollution tourists will find visibility drastically reduced, especially from Victoria Peak. People with serious respiratory problems should seek medical advice before travelling to the territory and ensure that they bring ample supplies of any medication.

Levels of pollution varies by season and weather. The winter monsoon can bring polluted air from the mainland, while the summer monsoon can bring cleaner air off the South China Sea.

The air is noticeably less foggy after rainy days.

Respect

Manners and etiquette

Hong Kong is a fast-paced society where the phrase "mm goi" (唔該), which literally means "I should not (bother you)", is used pervasively in a situation that you would say "Excuse me" or "Thank you".

The "mm goi" (I should not) mentality extends to a way that they don't want to bother anyone as long as possible. When you get a cough, always cover your mouth with the inner side of your elbow, as that area of your arm does not frequently come in contact with other people, thus avoiding the spread of pathogens. When having a fever, wear a mask. Spitting and littering, an offence subject to a penalty of \$3,000, is considered rude because it disturbs others. Hong Kong is noisy due to its huge population density but adding more noises, which will certainly disturb others too, is not welcome. Speaking vociferously over the phone on the bus, for example, will be viewed as egocentric and boorish.

When entering people's homes, always be sure to **remove your shoes** before you do so.

Hong Kong follows the British tradition in that **queue jumping is taboo** and you may easily get into an argument or be denied service if you do so. Everyone wants to go orderly and speedily on their way with the least disturbance. Even if an arriving bus is empty, and there are only two people waiting in line, they are expected to enter the bus in order of queue. Jumping a queue in order to ask a question is not tolerated either.

When smoking in front of a non-smoker, always ask for permission. Many smokers will just walk away to smoke, even in a place where smoking is legally allowed.

Unlike public transport in some large cities such as Tokyo or London, where it is common to see passengers eat or drink (even in a cautious manner that keeps the surroundings clean), such behaviour is strictly prohibited in all areas of MTR stations, train compartments (except intercity trains), and most buses. This is due to concerns about maintaining cleanliness of public facilities. If someone asks you to stop consuming or even dispose of your food when you're eating it obviously (for example, eating a hamburger and holding a coke), just obey the request and reply politely, and you'll always be out of trouble.

It is considered strange to strike up pleasantries with a stranger unless they are pregnant, disabled or senior citizens who are obviously in need. Saying "good morning" to a person you don't know at a bus stop will probably be viewed with suspicion.

Like their mainland Chinese counterparts, saving face is a part of Hong Kong culture. Mistakes are usually not pointed out directly in order to avoid causing embarrassment, and it is generally considered poor taste to brag about your achievements or flaunt your wealth in the face of your less well-to-do peers.

Naming customs and modes of address are generally the same as in mainland China, the main difference being that the names and titles are pronounced in Cantonese instead of Mandarin. Some upper class married women add their husband's surname in front of their surname, as in the examples of Carrie Lam and Anson Chan. Formally they should be referred to their husband's surname, though using both surnames is common in unofficial usages. See the Respect section of the China article for more details.

Religion

Many world religions are practised freely in Hong Kong, and discussing religion with local Hong Kong people is usually not a problem. Contemporary Hong Kong is, for the most part, rather secular in daily life, though you are expected to dress and behave in a respectful manner when

visiting places of worship. As in many other parts of Asia, swastikas are used in Hong Kong as a religious symbol for Buddhists, as well as for the Hindu minority, and have no connection with Nazism or anti-Semitism whatsoever.

When visiting Chinese temples, take off your hat. Avoid pointing at the statues of deities with your index finger. Use your thumb or an up-facing open palm instead.



Kowloon Masjid and Islamic Centre



It is common for both strangers and acquaintances who are Christian to ask you to come to their church, although offence will not usually be taken if you decline.

Traditional beliefs

Some traditional beliefs can be observed everywhere. Many buildings are influenced by the principles of Fengshui which refer to a decoration style that blends the Five Elements (gold, wood, water, fire, earth) together, which will turn out to bring you luck, fortune, better health, good examination results, good relationships, and even a baby boy, according to their believers.

Some prohibitions may not be noticed if you cannot speak Cantonese.

Many buildings skip floor numbers with a 4 in them; this includes the 14th and 24th floors (which phonetically mean "you must die" and "you die easily") and even the entire 40s range (so the 50th floor would be directly above the 39th floor). They love the numbers 18 (you will get rich), 369 (liveliness, longevity, lasting), 28 (easy to get rich), and 168 (get rich forever). This also extends to the licence plate numbers on their cars; 1358 is avoided as it phonetically means "you will never prosper", while numbers like 2328 (easy to procreate and prosper) are highly sought after.

When visiting your friends in Hong Kong, never give them a clock as a gift because "giving a clock" (送鍾) phonetically means "attending one's funeral" (送終). No pears will be served in a wedding party because "sharing a pear" (分梨) sounds like "separation" (分離).

Business

When you give or receive a business card, always do it with *both hands* and with a slight dip of your head or you may be seen as either disrespectful or ignorant. Welcoming someone should also be done with a slight dip of the head and with a customary firm handshake, but there is no need to bow.

Dress

When the thermometer hits 30 °C, expect to see many local people wearing warm clothing - this is to protect against the harsh air-conditioning often found on public transport and in places like cinemas and shopping malls. This is actually wise, since the extreme change in temperatures can make people feel ill.

In contrast, when the temperature starts to go under 20 °C, people start wearing very warm clothing to protect themselves from the 'cold'.

Hong Kong women are known for their fairly conservative dress code, although wearing halter-necks and sleeveless tops is not uncommon and acceptable, while teenagers and young adults can very frequently be seen wearing hot pants or short shorts. Public nudity including topless sunbathing is prohibited, even on the beach.

The dress code for men, especially tourists, is less conservative than it used to be. Even in 5-star hotels, smart casual is usually acceptable; although you might want to make your own enquiries in advance before dining in those places. Tourists from colder climates sometimes assume that wearing shorts in the tropics is a sensible idea, but hairy knees can look out of place in urban Hong Kong.

Sensitive topics

Relationship with mainland China

Hong Kong has significant cultural differences from mainland China due to its heritage and the Sino-Hong Kong relationship is a contentious and complicated issue. Some locals consider the mannerisms of mainland Chinese to be crude and uncivilised, and are grateful for what they consider to be the civilising influence of British colonial rule in Hong Kong. Meanwhile, some mainland Chinese criticise Hongkongers for what is perceived as a lack of ethnic solidarity and patriotism, along with arrogance rooted in its history of British colonial rule. Some Hongkongers also feel that China is wiping out Hong Kong's unique culture and attempting to impose Chinese culture on them. Generally speaking, it is best not to get into a discussion about mainland Chinese with local Hong Kong people.

Politics

In the 2020s the controversial National Security Law and other national security legislations were imposed and made advocacy or discussion of certain "red line" topics illegal. Discussion on some political subjects can be touchy. Also, political opinions can be polarised. Some locals may be offended if you imply that Hong Kong is/is not part of China. As a general rule, it's best to just stay clear of the topic unless you know your listener well. And generally it's a good idea to use terms like “mainland China” (中國大陸/中國內地/大陸/内地) to avoid irritating anyone.

Hong Kong people are somewhat free to criticise their government, as long as their criticism does not touch what the government calls "red line" issues. High-profile foreign critics are denied entry. National security education is now mandatory in schools and universities. A handful of websites are blocked but there's no widespread internet censorship. The Hong Kong Public Library initiated a campaign to censor and remove deemed subversive books. Media organisations that criticise the government face legal and economic pressure from authorities.

Local political parties are broadly split between pro-Beijing and pro-democracy camps, though the latter has been much dismantled after the National Security Law. While many desire universal suffrage, a right that Beijing has promised but refused to grant, some also try not to offend the mainland as Hong Kong's prosperity is thought to depend on further economic integration with China. The differences can also be observed on many topics such as the

Tiananmen Massacre in 1989 and democracy in China. In Hong Kong, where information has traditionally been freely circulated and people are well read, political opinions are extremely polarised. Generally, the older generation is split, while the younger generation is overwhelmingly pro-democracy and/or pro-independence.

A desire for stronger autonomy or even independence has been growing since the Umbrella Protests of 2014 by those increasingly frustrated by Beijing's reluctance to allow democratic reforms. Since the 2019 protests, all pro-independence and almost all pro-democratic lawmakers have been disqualified and expelled from the legislature, with many of them arrested under the National Security Law or seeking political asylum in other countries.

Connect

Post

Postal services are provided by **Hongkong Post (<https://www.hongkongpost.hk/>)**, which is generally efficient and reliable. Post offices and post boxes are ubiquitous, and postage label vending machines provide service when the post offices are closed. These machines accept Octopus cards, Alipay, WeChat Pay, and other forms of contactless payment. You can also buy stamps in sets of 10 from many convenience stores such as 7-Eleven or Circle K (OK). Postal rates are viewable online (https://www.hongkongpost.hk/en/postage_calculator/).

Due to Hong Kong's special status, Mainland Chinese or Macau stamps cannot be used in Hong Kong or vice versa.

Internet access

Unlike in mainland China, most Western websites are accessible in Hong Kong. However, as of July 2022, the new National Security Law has been used to block some websites critical of the government, though no large-scale censorship is implemented.

The international version of TikTok is unavailable in Hong Kong, but the main Western social media sites like Facebook, Twitter, YouTube and Instagram are available.

Internet cafes

Internet cafes have become rare as most people have smartphones and wifi-enabled devices. When available, internet cafes charge \$20-30 per hour.

Wi-Fi

Free Wi-Fi (<https://www.wi-fi.hk/>) is available at most hotels, shopping malls, coffee shops, the airport, most MTR stations, government buildings and some telephone booths.

Telephone

Hong Kong's country-code is +852 (different from mainland China (86) and Macau (853)). Local phone numbers (mobile and landlines) are typically 8 digits; no area codes are used. All numbers that begin with 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, or 9 are mobile numbers, while numbers beginning with 2 or 3 are fixed line numbers. For calls from Hong Kong, the standard IDD prefix is 001, so you would dial 001-(country code)-(area code)-(telephone number). Calls to Macau or mainland China require international dialling. For the operator, dial 1000. For **police, fire or ambulance services dial 999**.

Mobile phones

Hong Kong has a world class communications infrastructure, with a 5G network being deployed in 2020. Mobile phone usage is cheap and near-universal.

Hong Kong has many mobile operators. The best choices for tourists are Three (<https://www.three.com.hk/>), SmarTone (<https://www.smartone.com/en/>) and CSL (<https://www.hkcsl.com/en/>). All operators offer prepaid SIM cards in micro, nano, and standard sizes. Recharging your credit can be done online with a credit card (Three and CSL will accept credit cards from anywhere) or by purchasing vouchers from retail stores, resellers, convenience stores such as 7-Eleven and supermarkets. Unlimited data plans cost around \$28 per day.



Phone shop in the Sha Tin Plaza mall 

Since 1 March 2022, all new SIM cards sold must be registered with your name, and all existing SIM cards must be registered by 23 February 2023. A copy of your identity document or passport is also needed for registration.

The telephone system is separate from that of Mainland China, and using Chinese SIM card would incur roaming charges. China Mobile does offer its mainland prepaid customers a reduced rate option for Hong Kong; a fixed fee of 2.9RMB daily or 9 RMB weekly will reduce per-minute and per-SMS rates to mainland levels and incoming calls and SMS become free. Data, however, is separately charged at 30RMB daily for unlimited use.

Kiosks selling SIM Cards and renting mobile hotspot devices and mobile phones are available in the arrivals hall of the airport and at ferry terminals.

All mobile phone companies charge for *both* incoming and outgoing calls (similar to USA, but different from most European countries, Japan, Taiwan, or South Korea). Coverage is excellent, except in remote mountainous areas. Almost all operators provide a good signal, even when underground in such places as the MTR system, on board trains and in cross-harbour and other road tunnels.

Coverage is decent across all Hong Kong operators, comparison of the coverage and speeds of the networks can be found on [Hong Kong Coverage maps](https://www.opensignal.com/hong-kong) (<https://www.opensignal.com/hong-kong>) created by OpenSignal. In general Hong Kong has advanced mobile infrastructure with the second fastest LTE in the world.

For those traveling to the mainland, it is possible to buy SIMs with discounted pricing on mainland use. These are good to have if you need reliable uncensored internet on the mainland; due to the way roaming works, they are not blocked as a regular VPN would be during "sensitive" periods. China Unicom works on all phones, while China Mobile requires that your phone or internet device support the network technologies it uses on the mainland for 3G/4G access (TD-LTE and/or TD-SCDMA). China Unicom charges \$68/500MB or \$118/1GB for mainland data. China Mobile offers mainland data at \$48 daily (throttled to 128k after 1GB that day), \$98/2GB, or \$168/4GB.

Landline phones

Landline phones for local calls are charged on a monthly basis with unlimited access, but be careful that hotels may charge you per call.

Payphones are becoming rarer, but still exists in many MTR stations. If you don't have a mobile phone and need to make a short local call, most restaurants, supermarkets, and shops will allow you to use their phone if you ask nicely.

Cope

Media

“You guys (Hong Kong journalists) are good at one thing. Wherever you go to all over the world, you always run faster than Western journalists. But the questions you keep asking, are too simple, sometimes naive. Understand or not? Got it or not?”

Jiang Zemin, rage response to a Hong Kong journalist's questions in 2000.

Hong Kong has a vibrant press industry and a wide array of competing newspapers. However, media organisations that are critical of the government face political, legal, and economic pressures from the authorities. Moreover, the national security law has made the advocacy of some political positions, including Hong Kong independence and sanctions from foreign governments, illegal. Some prominent pan-democratic media were also forced to close after their executive members were arrested under that law.

The *Oriental Daily News* (<https://orientaldaily.on.cc/>) (東方日報) is one of Hong Kong's most widely circulated tabloids, adopting an informal writing style and focusing on celebrity coverage. Oriental Daily News is regarded as heavily biased towards the Beijing government.

Among the broadsheet Chinese-language newspapers that adopt a more formal style and focus on serious news, *Ming Pao* (<https://news.mingpao.com/>) (明報) is widely considered to be one of the most credible, and adopts a moderate editorial stance. The pro-establishment *Sing Tao Daily* (<https://news.mingpao.com/>) (星島日報) is its main competitor, while the *Hong Kong Economic Times* (<https://www.hket.com/>) (香港經濟日報) is the main financial newspaper.

The ***South China Morning Post*** (<https://www.scmp.com/>) is Hong Kong's English-language newspaper of record, while ***The Standard*** (<https://www.thestandard.com.hk/>), which adopts a more informal tabloid style and is distributed for free, is its main competitor. The online pro-democracy newspaper ***Hong Kong Free Press*** (<https://hongkongfp.com>) is also prominent and can be accessed for free.

Radio Television Hong Kong (<https://www.rthk.hk/>) is the Government broadcaster. Once given broad autonomy, it has been subject to increasing censorship by authorities. RTHK also make timely traffic broadcast (in Chinese) (<https://programme.rthk.hk/channel/radio/trafficnews/index.php>), which is accurate and useful for drivers and travellers in general.

Electricity

See also: [Electrical systems](#)

Hong Kong uses the British (type G) three-pin electrical sockets. Additionally, some hotels will have a bathroom with a parallel three-pin outlet which is designed for use with electric shavers, but might be used to re-charge a phone or rechargeable batteries. Electricity is 220 volts at 50 hertz. Most electronic stores will have cheap adapters that will allow foreign plugs to fit into British sockets, but these will not convert voltage or frequency.

Religion

The Chinese majority generally practises a mix of traditional Chinese folk religions and Buddhism. There are Hindus and Muslims, mostly of South Asian origin, and the territory is also home to several Hindu temples, mosques and a Sikh Gurdwara. Christianity is followed by 10% of the population, with English language services available all over the territory. Due to the presence of a large community of Filipino migrant workers, some churches also offer services in Tagalog. Protestants in Hong Kong tend to be strongly conservative. The Roman Catholic church is allowed to operate in Hong Kong. There is a single Orthodox synagogue, the Ohel Leah Synagogue, serving the tiny Jewish community.

Unlike in mainland China, the Falun Gong religion is permitted in Hong Kong, though their followers face pressure under the National Security Law.

Consulates

Although the embassies for China are in [Beijing](#), the special status of Hong Kong means that many consulates operate almost as full embassies (but are not allowed to be called embassies) from the perspective of the traveller in terms of assistance and visa needs. A few (mostly Portuguese-speaking) countries serve Hong Kong through their consulate in [Macau](#). We also list the representative offices of mainland China and Taiwan here, as they effectively serve as consulates from a traveller's point of view.

Almost any travel agent can also help you get a visa, and most can deliver it the next day. Of course they charge an additional fee, but it may be worth it for the convenience. The China Travel Service office on the arrivals level at the airport is often used. Keep in mind that you *cannot* apply for a Chinese visa in Hong Kong unless you are a legal resident.

Diplomatic missions	list [Expand]
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Go next

- [Macau](#), the former Portuguese colony and largest gambling haven in the world, is an hour away by [TurboJet](http://www.turbojet.com.hk) (<http://www.turbojet.com.hk>) ferry (around HK\$200) from the city centre

(near the Sheung Wan MTR station on Hong Kong Island), or 40 minutes away by shuttle bus (HK\$65) over the Hong Kong–Zhuhai–Macau bridge (but requiring another bus and an MTR ride to get to the bridge port).

- Shenzhen, mainland China's boomtown just across the border, can be reached by high speed rail in less than 20 minutes. The MTR East Rail Line takes longer at about 45 min, but is cheaper, and is connected to the Shenzhen Metro on the mainland side of the border. Another alternative, especially if you are starting from the island, is the ferry to Shekou, which takes around 50 minutes and costs around \$100. Depending on your nationality and method of transport, you may need to pre-arrange a visa to enter Shenzhen. Many locals head over to Shenzhen for cheaper shopping, dining and spa experiences than what would be available in Hong Kong.
- Zhuhai in mainland China, across the border from Macau, is 40 minutes by shuttle bus over the Hong Kong–Zhuhai–Macau bridge or 70 minutes away by ferry.
- Guangzhou, capital of mainland China's Guangdong Province, can be reached by train in around 45 minutes by HSR from West Kowloon station. If you are on a budget, many cross border buses are available throughout Hong Kong. The trip will take more than 3 hours, including going through customs at the border and changing buses.
- Taiwan, a common short-term destination for locals that is 1.5 hours away by plane. It is both a world-class technology hub and another great example of traditional Chinese culture.
- Singapore, a Southeast Asian city-state that is often regarded as a rival of Hong Kong, about 3.5 hours away by plane. Given its small size, a trip to Singapore by Hongkongers will almost always be coupled with visits to neighbouring Malaysia and Thailand.

Routes through Hong Kong (high-speed rail)

<u>Guangzhou</u> ← <u>Shenzhen</u> ← 	N	S	→ END
<u>Beijing</u> ← <u>Shenzhen</u> ← 	N	S	→ END
<u>Shanghai</u> ← <u>Shenzhen</u> ← 	NE	SW	→ END

Routes through Hong Kong (road)

<u>Shenzhen</u> ← 	N 10 S	→ END
<u>Macao</u> ← 	W 94 E	→ END
<u>Zhuhai</u> ← 	W 94 E	→ END

